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Initial public offer of equity shares on the main board of BSE Limited ("BSE") and National Stock Exchange of India Limited ("NSE"), and together with BSE, the "Stock Exchanges") in compliance with Chapter II of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Issue of Capital and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2018, as amended ("SEBI ICDR Regulations").



PRANAV CONSTRUCTIONS LIMITED
(TO BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF BSE AND NSE)

Our Company was originally incorporated as "Pranav Constructions Private Limited", a private limited company under the provisions of the Companies Act, 1956, pursuant to a certificate of incorporation dated July 31, 2003, issued by the Registrar of Companies, Maharashtra at Mumbai. The name of our Company was subsequently changed to "Pranav Constructions Limited", upon conversion of the Company from a private limited to a public limited company, pursuant to a Board resolution dated June 1, 2024, and a Shareholders resolution dated June 5, 2024, and a fresh certificate of incorporation was issued on July 29, 2024, by the Registrar of Companies, Central Processing Centre. For details of the changes in the name and the registered and corporate office of our Company, see "History and Certain Corporate Matters" on page 240 of the red herring prospectus dated August 31, 2026 ("RHP") filed with the RoC read with Corrigendum to the RHP dated September 1, 2026.

Registered and Corporate Office: Unit No. 1001, 10th Floor, DLH Park, Near MTNL, S.V. Road, Goregaon (West), Mumbai – 400 104;

Contact Person: Ritu Jain, Company Secretary and Compliance Officer; Telephone: +91 22 6276 9939; E-mail: compliance.officer@pranavconstructions.com; Website: www.pranavconstructions.com; Corporate Identity Number: U70101MH2003PLC141547

OUR PROMOTERS: PRANAV KIRAN ASHAR AND RAVI RAMALINGAM

INITIAL PUBLIC OFFER OF UP TO [•] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH ("EQUITY SHARES") OF PRANAV CONSTRUCTIONS LIMITED (OUR "COMPANY" OR THE "COMPANY" OR THE "ISSUER") FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹[•] PER EQUITY SHARE (INCLUDING A PREMIUM OF ₹[•] PER EQUITY SHARE) (THE "OFFER PRICE") AGGREGATING UP TO ₹[•] MILLION (THE "OFFER") COMPRISING A FRESH ISSUE OF UP TO [•] EQUITY SHARES BY OUR COMPANY AGGREGATING UP TO ₹3,156.00 MILLION (THE "FRESH ISSUE") AND AN OFFER FOR SALE OF UP TO 2,856,869 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH BY BIOURJA INDIA INFRA PRIVATE LIMITED AGGREGATING UP TO ₹[•] MILLION (SUCH OFFER FOR SALE OF EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH BY THE SELLING SHAREHOLDER, THE "OFFER FOR SALE"). THE OFFER SHALL CONSTITUTE [•]% OF THE POST-OFFER PAID UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL OF OUR COMPANY.

DETAILS OF THE SELLING SHAREHOLDER, OFFER FOR SALE AND WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION			
NAME OF THE SELLING SHAREHOLDER	TYPE	MAXIMUM NUMBER OF OFFERED SHARES	WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION* PER EQUITY SHARE (₹)
BioUrja India Infra Private Limited	Investor Selling Shareholder	Up to 2,856,869 Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each aggregating up to ₹[•] million.	42.55

*As certified by Agrawal Jain & Gupta, Chartered Accountants, Independent Chartered Accountants of our Company, by way of their certificate dated August 31, 2026.

PRICE BAND: ₹118 TO ₹124 PER EQUITY SHARE OF FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH.
THE FLOOR PRICE IS 11.80 TIMES THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES AND THE CAP PRICE IS 12.40 TIMES THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES.
BIDS CAN BE MADE FOR A MINIMUM OF 120 EQUITY SHARES BEARING FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH AND IN MULTIPLES OF 120 EQUITY SHARES THEREAFTER.
THE PRICE TO EARNINGS RATIO ("P/E") BASED ON DILUTED EPS FOR FISCAL 2026 AT THE LOWER END OF THE PRICE BAND (i.e FLOOR PRICE) IS 14.43 TIMES AND AT THE UPPER END OF THE PRICE BAND (i.e CAP PRICE) IS 15.16 TIMES AS COMPARED TO THE AVERAGE INDUSTRY PEER GROUP P/E RATIO OF 113.46 TIMES FOR FISCAL 2026.
WEIGHTED AVERAGE RETURN ON NET WORTH FOR LAST THREE FINANCIAL YEARS IS 43.44%.

The details of the Fresh Issue, Offer for Sale and the post Offer market capitalization of the Company, each at the Floor Price and the Cap Price, are given below:					
Particulars	At Floor Price of ₹118 each		At Cap Price of ₹124 each		
	Upto nos. of Equity Shares of Face Value ₹10 each	Upto amount (₹ in Million)	Upto nos. of Equity Shares of Face Value ₹10 each	Upto amount (₹ in Million)	
Fresh Issue	26,745,762	3,156.00	25,451,612	3,156.00	
Offer For Sale	2,856,869	337.11	2,856,869	354.25	
Total Offer Size	29,602,631	3,493.11	28,308,481	3,510.25	
Post Offer Market Capitalisation of Company	113,916,932	13,442.20	112,622,782	13,965.23	

BID / OFFER PERIOD	BID/OFFER OPENS TODAY
	BID/OFFER CLOSING DATE WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 09, 2026 ⁽¹⁾

⁽¹⁾UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5:00 pm on the Bid/Offer Closing Date.

We are a real estate company with a total of 1,864 units and 34 MCGM – Redevelopment projects (completed and under construction) launched between CY 17 – Q1 CY 26. We are amongst the redevelopment companies based out of Mumbai predominantly undertaking redevelopment projects in the Western Suburbs focusing on Economical, Mid and Mass, and Aspirational homes (Source: C&W Report).

THE OFFER IS BEING MADE THROUGH THE BOOK BUILDING PROCESS IN ACCORDANCE WITH REGULATION 6(1) OF THE SEBI ICDR REGULATIONS.
THE EQUITY SHARES OF THE COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARDS OF BSE LIMITED (BSE) AND NATIONAL STOCK EXCHANGE OF INDIA LIMITED (NSE). NSE SHALL BE THE DESIGNATED STOCK EXCHANGE.
• QIB PORTION: NOT MORE THAN 40% OF THE OFFER • NON-INSTITUTIONAL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 15% OF THE OFFER • RETAIL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 45% OF THE OFFER

IN MAKING AN INVESTMENT DECISION, POTENTIAL INVESTORS MUST RELY ONLY ON THE INFORMATION INCLUDED IN THE RHP AND THE TERMS OF THE OFFER, INCLUDING THE RISKS INVOLVED AND NOT RELY ON ANY OTHER EXTERNAL SOURCES OF INFORMATION ABOUT THE OFFER AVAILABLE IN ANY MANNER. IN RELATION TO PRICE BAND, POTENTIAL INVESTORS SHOULD ONLY REFER TO THIS PRICE BAND ADVERTISEMENT FOR THE OFFER AND SHOULD NOT RELY ON ANY MEDIA ARTICLES/ REPORTS IN RELATION TO THE VALUATION OF THE COMPANY AS THESE ARE NOT ENDORSED, PUBLISHED OR CONFIRMED EITHER BY THE COMPANY OR THE BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS TO THE OFFER ("BRLMs").

IN ACCORDANCE WITH THE RECOMMENDATION OF THE COMMITTEE OF INDEPENDENT DIRECTORS OF OUR COMPANY, PURSUANT TO THEIR RESOLUTION DATED SEPTEMBER 01, 2026, THE ABOVE PROVIDED PRICE BAND IS JUSTIFIED BASED ON QUANTITATIVE FACTORS/ KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATORS ("KPIs") DISCLOSED IN THE "BASIS FOR OFFER PRICE" SECTION BEGINNING FROM PAGE 124 OF THE RHP VIS-A-VIS THE WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION ("WACA") OF PRIMARY AND SECONDARY TRANSACTION(S), AS APPLICABLE, AS DISCLOSED IN THE "BASIS FOR OFFER PRICE" SECTION BEGINNING FROM PAGE 124 OF THE RHP.

Risk to Investors

For details, refer to section titled "Risk Factors" on page 18 of the RHP.

1. **Geographic concentration:** Our Redevelopment activities are geographically concentrated in the MCGM Region, which has accounted for 99.70%, 99.69% and 99.50% of our revenue from operations for Fiscal 2026, Fiscal 2025 and Fiscal 2024, respectively.

Particulars	Consolidated		
	Fiscal 2026	Fiscal 2025	Fiscal 2024
Revenue from operations (in ₹ million)	7,615.96	6,362.72	4,474.83
Revenue from operations as a percentage of total income (%)	99.70%	99.69%	99.50%

2. **Risk of completion of construction:** An inability to complete our Under-construction Redevelopment Projects and Upcoming Redevelopment Projects by their respective expected completion dates or in achieving milestones as mentioned in the agreement may subject us to RERA mandated penalties, interest payments and cancellation liabilities. Such delays could also lead to customer dissatisfaction, negative publicity, litigation, loss of buyer confidence, revocation of approvals, and failure to realize expected project economics.
3. **Risk of timely delivery:** Rapid escalation in property prices lead to significant challenges, particularly for economical and mid & mass groups. This scenario drastically reduces housing affordability, which in turn diminishes overall demand and can result in a slowdown of market activity. Our Company's operations are concentrated on the construction of Economical, Mid and Mass and Aspirational homes, escalation in property prices may impact the purchasing power of our customers, curtail our ability to sell units, and may have an adverse impact on our business and revenue from operations.
4. **Supplier concentration and absence of agreements:** We do not enter into agreements for supply of construction materials for our Redevelopment Projects and depend on a limited number of suppliers for construction materials. As of Fiscal 2026, Fiscal 2025 and Fiscal 2024, our top 10 suppliers contributed to 61.78%, 69.80% and 52.50% of the total material costs, respectively. If, for any reason, our suppliers of construction materials curtail or discontinue their delivery of such construction materials to us in the quantities we need, or we are unable to source from alternative suppliers on commercially acceptable terms or if we are unable to source from alternative suppliers, our Redevelopment Project schedule could be disrupted, and our business and results of operations could be adversely affected.
5. **Concentration of contractors:** Our Company avails services of independent contractors for construction of our Redevelopment Projects based on work contracts. We depend on a limited number of third party contractors to construct our Redevelopment Projects and if a contractor fails to perform its obligations satisfactorily or within the prescribed time periods with regard to a Redevelopment Project, or terminates its arrangement with us, we may be unable to develop the Redevelopment Project within the intended timeframe and within the anticipated budget. The table below provides the percentage of amount paid to our top 10 contractors for the periods indicated:

Particulars	Consolidated		
	Fiscal 2026	Fiscal 2025	Fiscal 2024
Total amount paid to contractors (in ₹ million)	673.74	626.96	347.68
Top five contractors as a % of total amount paid to contractors	32.29%	37.43%	30.60%
Top 10 contractors as a % of total amount paid to contractors	47.10%	56.41%	46.92%

6. **Acquisition of Redevelopment Projects:** We may not be able to successfully identify and acquire Redevelopment Projects in the future, which may have an adverse impact on our business and the growth of our Company.
7. **Irregularities in the title or use of land of Redevelopment Projects:** We have entered into Redevelopment agreements with Co-operative Housing Societies to acquire Redevelopment rights which may entail risks pertaining to irregularities in the title or use of land for which we have acquired Redevelopment rights which could have an adverse impact on our business operations and financial performance.
8. **Financial risk:** Our business requires significant expenditure for Redevelopment Projects and is dependent on the availability of financing, which may not be available on terms acceptable to us in a timely manner or at all. Our inability to

obtain funding on reasonable terms, or at all, could affect our ability to construct our Redevelopment Projects and would have an adverse effect on our business and results of operations. The table below provides brief details of our borrowings for the periods indicated:

(in ₹ million)

Particulars	Consolidated		
	As at March 31, 2026	As at March 31, 2025	As at March 31, 2024
Secured borrowings	2,348.39	1,528.95	563.43
Unsecured borrowings	236.04	436.02	429.92
Total borrowings	2,584.43	1,964.97	993.35

9. **Penalty risk under the Redevelopment agreements:** We are subject to penalty clauses under the Redevelopment agreements entered into with Co-operative Housing Societies for any delay in the completion or defects in construction of the Redevelopment Projects. Any inability to complete these constructions in a timely manner or at all, may result in termination of Redevelopment agreement by the Co-operative Housing Societies and may result in penalties. We have not faced any penalties in the past. Further, we are required to pay displacement compensation to the members of the Co-operative Housing Societies we re-develop. In cases of delay in construction of our Redevelopment Projects, our Company may be required to pay displacement compensation to the members for such extended period which may affect the overall profitability of the Redevelopment Projects. Any displacement compensation for the extended period, if paid, may affect the overall profitability of the Redevelopment Project and therefore adversely affect our business, results of operation and financial condition. Further, any delays in completing our Redevelopment Projects as scheduled could result in dissatisfaction among the Co-operative Housing Societies, resulting in negative publicity impacting our brand name and goodwill, consumer litigation and lack of confidence among future customers for our Redevelopment Projects.
10. We have experienced negative cash flows in Fiscal 2026 and Fiscal 2025, primarily due to the inherent nature of real estate development and redevelopment. The following table sets forth certain information relating to our cash flows for the years indicated:

(in ₹ million)

Particulars	Consolidated		
	Fiscal 2026	Fiscal 2025	Fiscal 2024
Net cash inflow/(outflow) from operating activities	(411.94)	(926.01)	54.62

11. Details of weighted average cost of acquisition of Equity Shares transacted in one year, 18 months and three years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus:

Period	Weighted average cost of acquisition per Equity Share (in ₹)*	Cap Price is 'x' times the weighted average cost of acquisition*	Range of acquisition price per Equity Share: lowest price – highest price (in ₹)*
Last one year preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus	240.00	0.52	240.00 - 240.00
Last 18 months preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus	240.00	0.52	240.00 - 240.00
Last three years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus	10.37	11.96	Nil – 4,130.00

*As certified by Agrawal Jain & Gupta, Chartered Accountants, Independent Chartered Accountants by way of their certificate dated September 01, 2026.

12. The weighted average return on net worth for the last three Fiscals is 43.44%.
13. The details of revenue from operations, EPS, price/earnings, net asset value, return on net worth for our Company

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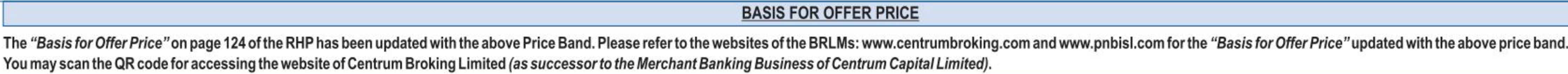
and our peer group are set out hereunder:

Notes:

(i) All the financial information for the Company mentioned above is based on the Restated Financial information, for the financial year ended March 31, 2026.

(ii) All the financial information for listed industry peer mentioned above is sourced from the audited financial statements of the relevant company for Fiscal 2026

1. The Company has not undertaken any pre-IPO placement.
2. The Promoters or members of the Promoter Group have not undertaken any transaction of shares aggregating up to 1% or more of the paid-up equity share capital of the Company from the date of Draft Red Herring Prospectus till date.

**Submission of Bids (other than Bids from Anchor Investors):**

^e UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 05:00 p.m. on Bid/Offer Closing Date.

(3) UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5:00 pm IST on Bid/ Offer Closing Date, i.e. Wednesday, September 09, 2026

(vi) EBITDA is calculated as PBT+ Interest+ Depreciation and Amortizations+ Finance cost.

Note: As certified by Agrawal Jain & Gupta, Chartered Accountants, Independent Chartered Accountants pursuant to their certificate dated September 01, 2026.

16. The average cost of acquisition of equity shares for the Investor Selling Shareholder in IPO is ₹42.55 and offer price at the upper end of the price band is ₹124.

Name of the BRLMs	Total Issues	Issues Closed below Offer Price
Centrum Broking Limited <i>(as successor to the merchant banking business of Centrum Capital Limited)</i>	4	3
PNB Investment Services Limited	3	0
Total	7	3

*Applications Supported by Blocked Amount
ASBA[™]) is a better way of applying to offers by
 simply blocking the fund in the bank account.
 For further details, check section on ASBA.

ASBA has to be availed by all the investors except Anchor Investors. UPI may be availed by (i) Retail Individual Investors in the Retail Category; (ii) Non-institutional Investors with an application size of up to ₹ 500,000 in the Non-Institutional Portion. For details on the ASBA and UPI process, please refer to the details given in the Bid Cum Application Form and Abridged Prospectus and also please refer to the section **"Offer Procedure"** on page 416 of the RHP. The process is also available on the website of Association of Investment Bankers of India ("**AIBI**") and Stock Exchanges and in the General Information Document. The Bid Cum Application Form and the Abridged Prospectus can be downloaded from the websites of the Stock Exchanges and can be obtained from the list of banks that is displayed on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedP=yes&intmid=35 and www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedP=yes&intmid=43, respectively as updated from time to time. For the list of UPI apps and banks live on IPO, please refer to the link: www.sebi.gov.in. UPI Bidders Bidding using the UPI Mechanism may apply through the SCSBs and mobile applications whose names appear on the website of SEBI, as updated from time to time. Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited and HDFC Bank Limited have been appointed as the Sponsor Banks for the Offer, in accordance with the requirements of SEBESE for the circular dated November 1, 2018 as amended. For Offer related queries, please contact the BRLMs at their respective email IDs as mentioned above. For UPI related queries, investors can contact NPCI at the toll free number: 18001201740 and mail ID: ipo_upi@npci.org.in.

In case of any revision in the Price Band, the Bid/Offer Period will be extended by at least three additional Working Days after such revision of the Price Band subject to the Bid/Offer Period not exceeding a total of 10 Working Days. In case of force majeure, banking strike or similar circumstances, our Company may, in consultation with the Book Running Lead Managers, for reasons to be recorded in writing, extend the Bid/Offer Period for a minimum of One Working Day, subject to the Bid/Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. Any revision in the Price Band and the revised Bid/Offer Period, if applicable, will be widely disseminated by notification to the Stock Exchanges, by issuing a public notice, and also by indicating the change on the respective websites of the Book Running Lead Managers and at the terminals of the other members of the Syndicate and by intimation to the other Designated Intermediaries and the Sponsor Bank(s), as applicable.

This is an Offer in terms of Rule 19(2)(b) the Securities Contracts (Regulation) Rules, 1957, as amended ("**SCRR**"), read with Regulation 31 of the SEBI ICDR Regulations. The Offer is being made through the Book Building Process in terms of Regulation 6(i) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations, wherein in terms of Regulation 32(i) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations, not more than 40% of the Offer shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to Qualified Institutional Buyers ("**QIBs**"), and such portion, the "QIB Portion") provided that our Company in consultation with the BRLMs, may allocate up to 60% of the QIB Portion to Anchor Investors on a discretionary basis in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations ("**Anchor Investor Portion**"). 40% of the Anchor Investor Portion shall be reserved for (i) 33.33% for domestic Mutual Funds, and (ii) 6.67% for Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds, subject to valid Bids being received from the domestic Mutual Funds, Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds, as applicable, at or above the Anchor Investor Allocation Price, subject to valid Bids being received from domestic Mutual Funds at or above the price at which allotment is made to the Anchor Investor ("**Anchor Investor Allocation Price**"). In the event of under-subscription in (ii) above, the allocation may be made to domestic Mutual Funds. In the event of under-subscription or non-allocation in the Anchor Investor Portion, the balance Equity Shares shall be added to the Net QIB Portion. Further, 5% of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis only to Mutual Funds and the remainder of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to all QIB Bidders (other than Anchor Investors) including Mutual Funds, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price. Further, not less than 15% of the Offer shall be available for allocation to Non-Institutional Bidders out of which (a) one-third of such portion shall be reserved for applicants with application size of more than ₹20 million and up to ₹1.00 million; and (b) two-third of such portion shall be reserved for applicants with application size of more than ₹1.00 million, provided that the unsubscribed portion in either of such sub-categories may be allocated to applicants in the other sub-category of Non-Institutional Bidders subject to valid bids being received at or above the Offer Price and not less than 45% of the Offer shall be available for allocation to Retail Individual Bidders ("**RIBs**") in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations, subject to valid Bids being received from them at or above the Offer Price. All potential Bidders (except Anchor Investors) are required to mandatorily utilise the Application Supported by Blocked Amount ("**ASBA**") process by providing details of their respective bank accounts (including UPI ID for UPI Bidders using UPI Mechanism) (as defined hereinafter) in which the Bid amount will be blocked by the SCSBs or the Sponsor Banks, as applicable, to participate in the Offer. Anchor Investors are not permitted to participate in the Anchor Investor Portion of the Offer through the ASBA process. For details, see "**Offer Procedure**" on page 416 of the RHP.

Bidders/Applicants should ensure that DP ID, PAN and the Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through UPI Mechanism) are correctly filled in the Bid cum Application Form. The DP ID, PAN and Client ID provided in the Bid cum Application Form should match with the DP ID, PAN, Client ID and UPI ID available in the Depository database. (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) in the Depository database, otherwise, the Bid cum Application Form is liable to be rejected. Bidders/Applicants should ensure that the beneficiary account provided in the Bid cum Application Form is active. Bidders/Applicants should note that on the basis of the PAN, DP ID, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) as provided in the Bid cum Application Form, the Bidder/Applicant may be deemed to have authorized the Depositories to provide to the Registrar to the Offer, any requested Demographic Details of the Bidder/Applicant as available on the records of the depositories. These Demographic Details may be used, among other things, for giving Allotment Advice or unblocking of ASBA Account or for other correspondence(s) related to the Offer. Bidders/Applicants are advised to update any changes to their Demographic Details as available in the records of the Depository Participant to ensure accuracy of records. Any delay resulting from failure to update the Demographic Details would be at the Bidders/Applicants' sole risk.

Contents of the Memorandum of Association of our Company as Regards its Objects: For information on the main objects of our Company, please see "**History and Certain Corporate Matters - Main objects of our Company**" on page 240 of the RHP. The Memorandum of Association of our Company is a material document for inspection in relation to the Offer. For further details, see "**Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection**" on page 461 of the RHP.

Liability of the Members of our Company: Limited by shares.

Amount of Share Capital of our Company and Capital Structure: As on the date of the RHP, the authorised share capital of our Company is ₹1,190,000,000 divided into 119,000,000 Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each. The issued, subscribed and paid-up Equity share capital of our Company is ₹871,711,700 divided into 87,171,170 Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each. For details of the capital structure of the Company, see “**Capital Structure**” beginning on page 76 of the RHP.

Names of the Initial Signatories to the Memorandum of Association of the Company and the Number of Equity Shares Subscribed by them: The initial signatories to the Memorandum of Association of the Company are as follows: 4,900 Equity Shares allotted to Pranav Kiran Ashar and 5,100 Equity Shares allotted to Kiran Dharamsey Ashar. For details of the share capital history of our Company please see ***“Capital Structure”*** beginning on page 76 of the RHP.

Listing: The Equity Shares to be offered through the Red Herring Prospectus are proposed to be listed on the Stock Exchanges. Our Company has received 'in-principle' approvals from the BSE and the NSE for the listing of the Equity Shares pursuant to their letters each dated May 28, 2025. For the purpose of the Offer, NSE is the Designated Stock Exchange. A signed copy of the Red Herring Prospectus and the Prospectus will be filed with the RoC in accordance with Section 26(4) and 32 of the Companies Act, 2013, respectively. For details of the material contracts and documents that will be available for inspection from the date of the Red Herring Prospectus up to the Bid/Offer Closing Date, see **"Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection"** on page 461 of the RHP.

Disclaimer Clause of Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI"): SEBI only gives its observations on the offer documents and this does not constitute approval of either the Offer or the specified securities stated in the Offer Documents. The investors are advised to refer to page 396 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of SEBI.

Disclaimer Clause of BSE: It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by BSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the RHP has been cleared or approved by BSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the RHP. The investors are advised to refer to the page 399 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of BSE.

Disclaimer Clause of NSE (the Designated Stock Exchange): It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by NSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the Offer Document has been cleared or approved by NSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the Offer Document. The investors are advised to refer to page 399 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of NSE.

General Risks: Investment in equity and equity-related securities involve a degree of risk and investors should not invest any funds in the Offer unless they can afford to take the risk of losing their entire investment. Investors are advised to read the risk factors carefully before taking an investment decision in the Offer. For taking an investment decision, investors must rely on their own examination of our Company and the Offer, including the risks involved. The Equity Shares in the Offer have not been recommended or approved by the SEBI, nor does SEBI guarantee the accuracy or adequacy of the contents of the Red Herring Prospectus. Specific attention of the investors is invited to **"Risk Factors"** on page 18 of the RHP.

AVAILABILITY OF THE RHP: Investors are advised to refer to the RHP and the “*Risk Factors*” beginning on page 18 of the RHP before applying in the Offer. A copy of the RHP will be made available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in and is available on the websites of the BRLMs, Centrum Broking Limited (*as successor to the merchant banking business of Centrum Capital Limited*) at www.centumbroking.com and PNB Investment Services Limited at www.pnbis.com and at the website of the Company, Pranav Constructions Limited at www.pranavconstructions.com and the websites of the Stock Exchanges, for BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and for National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com.

AVAILABILITY OF THE ABRIDGED PROSPECTUS: A copy of the Abridged Prospectus shall be available on the website of the Company, the BRLMs and the Registrar to the Offer at www.pranavconstructions.com, www.centrumbroking.com, www.pnbisl.com and www.kfintech.com, respectively.

AVAILABILITY OF BID/CUM APPLICATION FORM: Bid cum Application Form can be obtained from the Registered Office of our Company, **PRANAV CONSTRUCTIONS LIMITED**, Telephone: +91 22 6276 9939; **BR/MLs:** **Centrum Broking Limited** (as successor to the merchant banking business of *Centrum Capital Limited*), Telephone: +91 22 4215 9000; **PNEB Investment Services Limited**, Telephone: +91 22 6917 4200 and **Syndicate Members:** **Centrum Broking Limited**, Telephone: +91 22 4215 9000, Registered Brokers, SCSEBs Designated RTA Locations and Designated CDP Locations for participating in the Offer. Bid cum Application Forms will also be available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com and at all the Designated Branches of SCSEBs, the list of which is available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges and SEBI.

SUB-SYNDICATE MEMBERS: Anand Rathi Share & Stock Brokers Limited, Axis Capital Limited, HDFC Securities Limited, ICICI Securities Limited, IDBI Capital Markets Limited, Kotak Securities Limited, Laurus Capital Limited, M&M Securities Limited, NSE Global Services Limited, NSE Institutional Services Limited, NSE Market Services Limited, NSE Technology Services Limited, NSE Transaction Services Limited, NSE Clearing Services Limited, NSE Depository Services Limited, NSE Registrar Services Limited, NSE Settlement Services Limited, NSE Surveillance Services Limited, NSE Training Services Limited, NSE Research Services Limited, NSE Advisory Services Limited, NSE Consulting Services Limited, NSE Other Services Limited.

PRANAV CONSTRUCTIONS LIMITED is proposing, subject to receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offer of its Equity Shares of ₹ 10 each at a price of ₹ 100 per Equity Share of ₹ 10 each, aggregating to ₹ 100 crore, through the merchant banking business of Centrum Capital Limited (a company incorporated in India and having its registered office at 101, 102, 103, 104, 105, 106, 107, 108, 109, 110, 111, 112, 113, 114, 115, 116, 117, 118, 119, 120, 121, 122, 123, 124, 125, 126, 127, 128, 129, 130, 131, 132, 133, 134, 135, 136, 137, 138, 139, 140, 141, 142, 143, 144, 145, 146, 147, 148, 149, 150, 151, 152, 153, 154, 155, 156, 157, 158, 159, 160, 161, 162, 163, 164, 165, 166, 167, 168, 169, 170, 171, 172, 173, 174, 175, 176, 177, 178, 179, 180, 181, 182, 183, 184, 185, 186, 187, 188, 189, 190, 191, 192, 193, 194, 195, 196, 197, 198, 199, 200, 201, 202, 203, 204, 205, 206, 207, 208, 209, 210, 211, 212, 213, 214, 215, 216, 217, 218, 219, 220, 221, 222, 223, 224, 225, 226, 227, 228, 229, 230, 231, 232, 233, 234, 235, 236, 237, 238, 239, 240, 241, 242, 243, 244, 245, 246, 247, 248, 249, 250, 251, 252, 253, 254, 255, 256, 257, 258, 259, 260, 261, 262, 263, 264, 265, 266, 267, 268, 269, 270, 271, 272, 273, 274, 275, 276, 277, 278, 279, 280, 281, 282, 283, 284, 285, 286, 287, 288, 289, 290, 291, 292, 293, 294, 295, 296, 297, 298, 299, 300, 301, 302, 303, 304, 305, 306, 307, 308, 309, 310, 311, 312, 313, 314, 315, 316, 317, 318, 319, 320, 321, 322, 323, 324, 325, 326, 327, 328, 329, 330, 331, 332, 333, 334, 335, 336, 337, 338, 339, 340, 341, 342, 343, 344, 345, 346, 347, 348, 349, 350, 351, 352, 353, 354, 355, 356, 357, 358, 359, 360, 361, 362, 363, 364, 365, 366, 367, 368, 369, 370, 371, 372, 373, 374, 375, 376, 377, 378, 379, 380, 381, 382, 383, 384, 385, 386, 387, 388, 389, 390, 391, 392, 393, 394, 395, 396, 397, 398, 399, 400, 401, 402, 403, 404, 405, 406, 407, 408, 409, 410, 411, 412, 413, 414, 415, 416, 417, 418, 419, 420, 421, 422, 423, 424, 425, 426, 427, 428, 429, 430, 431, 432, 433, 434, 435, 436, 437, 438, 439, 440, 441, 442, 443, 444, 445, 446, 447, 448, 449, 450, 451, 452, 453, 454, 455, 456, 457, 458, 459, 460, 461, 462, 463, 464, 465, 466, 467, 468, 469, 470, 471, 472, 473, 474, 475, 476, 477, 478, 479, 480, 481, 482, 483, 484, 485, 486, 487, 488, 489, 490, 491, 492, 493, 494, 495, 496, 497, 498, 499, 500, 501, 502, 503, 504, 505, 506, 507, 508, 509, 510, 511, 512, 513, 514, 515, 516, 517, 518, 519, 520, 521, 522, 523, 524, 525, 526, 527, 528, 529, 530, 531, 532, 533, 534, 535, 536, 537, 538, 539, 540, 541, 542, 543, 544, 545, 546, 547, 548, 549, 550, 551, 552, 553, 554, 555, 556, 557, 558, 559, 560, 561, 562, 563, 564, 565, 566, 567, 568, 569, 570, 571, 572, 573, 574, 575, 576, 577, 578, 579, 580, 581, 582, 583, 584, 585, 586, 587, 588, 589, 590, 591, 592, 593, 594, 595, 596, 597, 598, 599, 600, 601, 602, 603, 604, 605, 606, 607, 608, 609, 610, 611, 612, 613, 614, 615, 616, 617, 618, 619, 620, 621, 622, 623, 624, 625, 626, 627, 628, 629, 630, 631, 632, 633, 634, 635, 636, 637, 638, 639, 640, 641, 642, 643, 644, 645, 646, 647, 648, 649, 650, 651, 652, 653, 654, 655, 656, 657, 658, 659, 660, 661, 662, 663, 664, 665, 666, 667, 668, 669, 670, 671, 672, 673, 674, 675, 676, 677, 678, 679, 680, 681, 682, 683, 684, 685, 686, 687, 688, 689, 690, 691, 692, 693, 694, 695, 696, 697, 698, 699, 700, 701, 702, 703, 704, 705, 706, 707, 708, 709, 710, 711, 712, 713, 714, 715, 716, 717, 718, 719, 720, 721, 722, 723, 724, 725, 726, 727, 728, 729, 730, 731, 732, 733, 734, 735, 736, 737, 738, 739, 740, 741, 742, 743, 744, 745, 746, 747, 748, 749, 750, 751, 752, 753, 754, 755, 756, 757, 758, 759, 760, 761, 762, 763, 764, 765, 766, 767, 768, 769, 770, 771, 772, 773, 774, 775, 776, 777, 778, 779, 780, 781, 782, 783, 784, 785, 786, 787, 788, 789, 790, 791, 792, 793, 794, 795, 796, 797, 798, 799, 800, 801, 802, 803, 804, 805, 806, 807, 808, 809, 810, 811, 812, 813, 814, 815, 816, 817, 818, 819, 820, 821, 822, 823, 824, 825, 826, 827, 828, 829, 830, 831, 832, 833, 834, 835, 836, 837, 838, 839, 840, 841, 842, 843, 844, 845, 846, 847, 848, 849, 850, 851, 852, 853, 854, 855, 856, 857, 858, 859, 860, 861, 862, 863, 864, 865, 866, 867, 868,

& Securities Limited, JFI Capital Services Limited, JM Financial Services Limited, Keynote Capitals Limited, KJMC Capital Market Services Limited, Kotak Securities Limited, LKP & Securities Limited, Mittal Oswal Financial Services Limited, Nuvama Wealth and Investment Limited, Prabhudas Lilladher Private Limited, Pravin Ratilal Share And Stock Brokers Limited, SBICAP Securities Limited, Sharekhan Limited, SMC Global Securities Limited, Asit C. Mehta Investment Intermediates Limited, RR Equity Brokers Private Limited, Yes Securities (India) Limited, and Zerodha Broking Limited.

ESCROW COLLECTION BANK: Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited. | **PUBLIC OFFER ACCOUNT BANK:** HDFC Bank Limited.

REFUND BANK: Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited. | **SPONSOR BANKS:** Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited and HDFC Bank Limited.

UPI: UPI Bidders can also bid through UPI Mechanism.

All capitalised terms used herein and not specifically defined shall have the same meaning as ascribed to them in the RHP.

Place: Mumbai, Maharashtra
Date: September 04, 2026

For **PRANAV CONSTRUCTIONS LIMITED**
On behalf of the Board of Directors

Place: Mumbai, Maharashtra
Date: September 04, 2026

The Equity Shares offered in the Offer have not been, and will not be, registered under the U.S. Securities Act and may not be offered or sold within the United States, except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws. The Equity Shares offered in the Offer are being offered and sold only outside the United States in "offshore transactions" as defined in and in reliance on Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act ("**Regulation S**") and the applicable laws of the jurisdiction where those offers and sales occur.

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SENSEX 76515.43 (-749.08)



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	23897.70	-277.95
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.27	-0.20
US Dollar (in ₹)	94.48	-0.89
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	154264.00	-4675
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	235456.00	-8436

NEW DIRECTION.

Tata Sons chief N Chandrasekaran will address Air India staff on Monday to welcome CEO-designate **p2**



BRANDLINE.

From liquor counters to Instagram checkouts, brands are turning risqué positioning into products **p8**

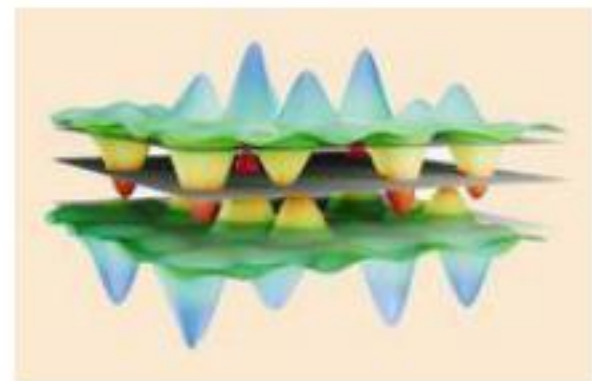
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MONDAY SPECIALS.

QUANTUM

A crystal that defies thermoelectric rules



Researchers from JNCASR, IISc and the University of Sydney have reported a record Seebeck coefficient in scandium nitride, challenging long-held limits for crystalline solids. This holds promise for a range of industrial uses, including ultrasensitive thermal and photon sensors. **p9**

LOGISTICS

Logistics firms brace for festival runs

Beginning with Onam in August and up to Pongal in January, India's festival calendar is turning into an extended peak season for the logistics industry, with the e-commerce, organised retail, consumer electronics, fashion and other consumer durables segments expected to push cargo and express volumes higher. What's different this year is not merely the quantum of demand. **p10**

FCNR(B) deluge softens CD rates; large banks stay away

FUNDING PUSH. Sub-6% certificate of deposit rates to keep mid & small lenders active

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai

Certificate of deposit (CD) rates have slipped below 6 per cent from the 7-7.25 per cent levels seen about three months ago, primarily due to the flood of liquidity generated by banks swapping Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) or FCNR(B) deposits with the Reserve Bank of India under its special concessional forex swap scheme.

The sharp decline in funding costs highlights the impact of the RBI's FCNR(B) window. By swapping \$127.23 billion of FCNR(B) deposits with the RBI, banks drew substantial rupee liquidity, curbing their need for CD funding.

LIQUIDITY IMPACT

The liquidity impact has been the most pronounced among large banks, which were the principal beneficiaries of the FCNR(B) scheme. Armed with fresh three-to-five-year FCNR(B) deposits and access to the RBI's concessional swap facility, these lenders have

EASING RATES

- FCNR(B) inflows drag CD rates below 6% as banks raise \$127.23 billion
- CD rates have fallen from 7-7.5% since June 8
- Mid and small lenders seek to benefit from lower wholesale funding costs
- Liquidity surplus of ₹10.31 lakh crore keeps rates soft



little incentive to access the CD market for near-term funding requirements.

"The excess liquidity is creating an interesting situation in the money market, with large banks not needing to raise much money and, at the same time, investors are sitting on large amounts of liquidity, looking for avenues to deploy it," said Venkatakrishnan Srinivasan, Founder and Managing Partner, Rockfort Fincap LLP.

He said the impact is clearly visible in market rates, with three-month CDs of top-rated banks trading as low as 5.8 per cent compared with levels above 7 per cent earlier. "Banks which don't need the money simply don't

come to the market, while banks which need to refinance or raise short-term funds are able to borrow at much cheaper rates as there is so much liquidity chasing bank paper. For larger banks, this is a good opportunity to refinance existing CDs and other relatively expensive short-term borrowings," he added.

KEY ISSUERS

In contrast, mid-size and smaller banks are expected to emerge as key issuers in the CD market in the coming months. Unlike their larger peers, many of them were unable to garner substantial FCNR(B) inflows because they lacked the balance-

sheet strength and customer relationships needed to provide leverage or standby letters of credit sought by the NRI depositors. With FCNR(B) liquidity concentrated among bigger lenders, these banks are likely to use the softer rate environment to raise short-term funds through CDs.

"For other banks, regular access to the CD market also helps them build and widen their institutional investor base. For these banks, therefore, it is not just about raising money. It is also about building relationships with mutual funds, banks, financial institutions and other institutional investors, while getting access to cheaper short-term funding," Venkatakrishnan said.

With surplus liquidity at ₹10.31 lakh crore and set to rise further as banks complete FCNR(B) swaps, the CD rates are expected to remain soft. While large banks may stay away from the market, smaller lenders could use the low-rate environment to raise funds at lower costs before the liquidity conditions normalise.

Ahead of listing, NSE revives 'permitted to trade' universe with 250 securities

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

The National Stock Exchange (NSE) has significantly expanded its "permitted to trade" universe this year, adding 250 securities to a segment that had seen little activity in recent years.

The expansion comes at a time when the NSE is moving closer to its long-awaited listing and considering whether its own shares could eventually trade on its platform.

The NSE added 106 securities with effect from April 20 and another 144 from August 17. The last addition to the category was in 2022. The BSE currently has 30 companies under its permitted-to-trade (PTT) category.

TRADING FRENZY

The first batch has already seen a sharp increase in trading activity, with average daily turnover rising from about ₹92 crore on the BSE to around ₹400 crore across the NSE and the BSE after the securities became available for trading on both exchanges.

The jump in volumes shows the potential liquidity benefit of allowing a security listed on one exchange to



106 of the 250 securities saw a four-fold jump in turnover after admission to the NSE

Friday, SEBI gave the NSE final approval to proceed with its listing, which is expected by September 25.

ELIGIBILITY CRITERIA

While PTT allows securities to trade on the NSE without listing, companies need to meet the NSE's eligibility criteria for a direct listing. Of the 250 securities added, only 25 appear to meet the exchange's existing direct-listing criteria.

Around 110 companies do not meet the ₹10 crore paid-up capital requirement, while 234 do not meet the revenue criterion and 47 do not meet the positive-EBITDA criterion. On market capitalisation, 214 companies were found ineligible.

Meanwhile, the trading activity of the scrip is subject to all surveillance measures like any other listed scrip. As many as 127 of the 250 securities have been subject to measures such as the Additional Surveillance Measure (ASM) or Graded Surveillance Measure (GSM).

The expansion of the PTT universe and the liquidity it has generated come when the NSE is seeking permission to trade its own shares on the platform, potentially strengthening the case for the proposed arrangement.

Strong prices expected for most kharif crops

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

With the kharif crops set to arrive in the mandis in about 10 days, farmers in top-producing States are expected to receive favourable market prices. The only notable concerns are bajra (pear millet) and moong (green gram), which are lagging behind at 31 per cent and 13 per cent below their MSPs.

Nine out of 14 kharif crops for which MSPs have been announced, including maize, jowar, tur, urad and soybean, were sold on average either at par with their respective MSP (of the 2026-27 season) or higher on September 4, according to Agmarknet data.

In the case of paddy, the key kharif crop in which market rates are influenced by government procurement, currently the average price in Uttar Pradesh is ₹1,965/quintal, the data show.

Despite reports of some

Mandi prices ahead of kharif crops arrival (₹/quintal)

	Avg price**	MSP*	% change
Maize	2,684	2,410	11.4
Jowar	4,381	4,023	8.9
Tur	8,475	8,450	0.3
Urad	8,210	8,200	0.1
Soybean	5,674	5,708	-0.6
Groundnut	6,900*	7,517	-8.2
Moong	7,662	8,780	-12.7
Paddy	1,965	2,461	-20.2
Bajra	1,998	2,900	-31.1

*For 2026-27 season; ** in top-producing State on Sept 4, 2026; *In Rajasthan

likely productivity losses due to the impact of El Nino, the mandi prices of bajra, paddy, moong, groundnut and soybean are ruling in negative, ranging from 0.6 per cent to 31 per cent over their next season's MSP. Maize, jowar, tur and urad are over their MSP by up to 11 per cent.

HIGHER PRICES

"There is no problem with paddy as the government has been procuring 40 per cent of production. Once the purchase starts (which varies

from State to State), mandi prices, too, pick up. This time, soybean prices are higher compared to last year, despite strong import of its oil. The groundnut crop in Gujarat also looks good this year and its prices are also expected to move up," said a former Additional Secretary in the Agriculture Ministry.

Maize price, which is ruling higher, is likely to fall once the crop arrives as its demand will compete with other animal feed like soy-meal and DDGS, he added.

"Going by the historical data and El Nino impact in the previous years, there seems to be definite production loss this season. The market is already sensitive to it, which is factored in present prices. The sudden drop in soybean is surprising, which should not hold for long as cartelisation seems to be the reason for it," said SK Singh, a former additional MD of Nafed.

Overall, major crops should see prices aligned with their MSP for their FAQ grade, except moong where stock disposal by government agencies may keep prices below MSP, he added.

In the current year, the sowing area under maize is lower by 3 per cent at 91 lakh hectares (lh) from the year-ago level. Similarly, paddy acreage, too, trails by 4 per cent at 421.82 lh. The area under soybean and groundnut is lower by 1 lh from the year-ago number, official data as of September 4 show.

Motor insurance gets a personal touch

Insurers offer own-damage add-ons, named-driver plans and mileage-linked premium

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

Motor insurance is increasingly moving away from a one-size-fits-all approach to a personalised cover tailoring the premium to the risks specific to the vehicle and policyholder, thanks to a data-driven approach.

The personalisation in the own-damage component is visible in the growing range of modular covers available to customers, including return to invoice, nil depreciation, consumables cover and engine protector, and allowing policyholders to build protection around their individual requirements.

"Motor insurance in India has steadily evolved towards greater personalisation and customer-centricity. Customers today have the flexibility to opt for coverage that makes their



Personalisation is linking insurance more closely to actual vehicle usage and driving patterns

insurance modular and comprehensive," said Amarnath Saxena, Chief Technical Officer-Commercial, Bajaj General Insurance.

USAGE-BASED COVER

Personalisation is linking insurance more closely to actual vehicle usage and driving patterns. Usage-based motor insurance, for instance, allows customers to declare the distance they expect to drive in a year, with the premium aligned to

that usage. A customer declaring an annual usage of, say, 10,000 km can, therefore, have the cover structured around the expected extent of vehicle use.

There is also 'Named Driver' cover, under which the insured declares the licensed individuals who will drive the vehicle. This information can have a direct bearing on risk assessment and pricing, Saxena said.

Insurers are also offering bundled add-ons, combining multiple protections into a single package.

Personalisation is also extending to occupational requirements as insurers are now tailoring cover to specific employment requirements, including those of defence personnel.

Amit Goel, Director & Principal Officer, Equirius Raghna Insurance Broking, said: "Motor insurance is gradually moving from

being an asset-based product to a data- and usage-driven product."

DIGITAL DRIVE

According to Ramit Goyal, Chief Distribution Officer, Generali Central Insurance, digital platforms are further reshaping the business model by simplifying the entire customer journey, prompting insurers to invest in automation, artificial intelligence, analytics and digital claims management capabilities.

"The motor insurance business is expected to become increasingly digital, data-led and customer-centric," he said.

Connected vehicles could eventually provide insurers with richer information on driving behaviour, vehicle usage, location, mileage and risk patterns, creating the possibility of more sophisticated risk-based pricing.

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QUICKLY.

Rajnath Singh to travel to Sri Lanka on 3-day trip

New Delhi: Defence Minister Rajnath Singh will undertake a three-day trip to Sri Lanka, beginning Tuesday, to explore ways to further shore up bilateral defence and military ties. Singh will be accompanied by a high-level delegation comprising senior officials from the Defence and External Affairs Ministries, according to an official statement. “Defence Minister Rajnath Singh will undertake an official visit to Sri Lanka from September 8 to 10,” the Defence Ministry said.

Karnataka govt to retain Old Pension Scheme

Bengaluru: The Karnataka government will soon scrap the New Pension Scheme (NPS) and implement the Old Pension Scheme (OPS), Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara said on Saturday. He said that the reintroduction of the OPS was a long-standing demand of government employees. “The Chief Minister has held discussions on the issue. The government has taken an important decision to scrap the NPS and implement the OPS soon,” Parameshwara said at an event here.

VinFast gears up for E2W foray, looks for local dealers

FRESH LEAP. Firm to assemble its products through completely knocked down route

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

VinFast India has taken next major step towards entering the country's electric two-wheeler (E2W) market. The company has initiated plans to appoint dealers across India even as it prepares for the local assembly of electric scooters, according to industry sources.

In a recent social media post, VinFast invited applications for exclusive VinFast E-Motorcycle dealership opportunities across the country, signalling that its India two-wheeler launch could be drawing closer.

“Something massive is building at VinFast E-Motorcycle India, and we are about to open the doors to a historic journey,” the company said in the advertisement.

VinFast said it was looking to build an ecosystem around smart and sustainable electric mobility and sought partners who could help expand its presence across the country.

VinFast registrations

EV WAVE

- Move comes when India's E2W market is gaining momentum
- Components will be imported
- The assembly will take place at its facility in Thoothukudi, Tamil Nadu



jumped 43.5 per cent m-o-m to 2,196 units in August from 1,530 in July. “The blueprint is ready. The ground is set. A major announcement is dropping very soon,” the post said, adding that applications from prospective dealers would be accepted until September 15.

DEALERSHIPS

VinFast's move comes at a time when India's electric two-wheeler market is gaining momentum, supported by growing consumer acceptance, expanding charging infrastructure and a wider range of products.

The Vietnamese automobile major is understood to be working on production through the completely

knocked down (CKD) route, with components imported from its overseas facilities and electric two-wheelers assembled at its car manufacturing plant in Thoothukudi, Tamil Nadu.

On VinFast's E2W plans, S Sathyanarayanan, a two-wheeler dealer in Vilupuram, said the E2W industry offered considerable room for growth.

Electric two-wheelers account for only around 9 per cent of the overall two-wheeler market, compared with conventional internal combustion engine vehicles, he said. Sathyanarayanan plans to apply for a VinFast dealership.

“VinFast has experience in this segment. India is a big

country, with different States having different festivals at various times of year. To understand this and be present near to buyers, dealerships are required,” Bharat Kumar Chordia, Treasurer, FADA, said.

NO CHANGES

When asked about the variants of the electric two-wheelers, Vinfast did not elaborate at the time of writing. The E2W development comes in the backdrop of a recent *Reuters* report stating that the company is suspending production plans for some car variants in India. However, Vinfast said that, “For the models currently being sold in India, VinFast has not changed or suspended its production plans as suggested by Reuters' sources. VinFast will continue CKD assembly of these models at its Thoothukudi plant to serve the Indian market.”

VinFast said it will invest \$500 million in Thoothukudi to develop workshops and production lines for e-buses and e-scooters.

Tata Sons Chairman to address Air India town hall today

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai



N Chandrasekaran

Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran will address Air India staff in a town hall meeting on Monday.

While the meeting is meant to welcome new Chief Executive Officer-designate Tewolde Gebremariam, Chandrasekaran, popularly known as Chandra, is also expected to lay a roadmap for the airline. This would also be a first interaction between Gebremariam and Air India employees.

Gebremariam, who is the former group CEO of Ethiopian Airlines, is also expected to meet the department heads separately.

The employee engagement is taking place as Air India seeks fund infusion from its two shareholders — Tata Sons and Singapore Airlines.

While the board of Tata Sons is said to have given an in-principle approval to invest around ₹10,000 crore in the airline, Singapore Airlines has said it will carefully consider funding requests from Air India.

“Equity will have to be infused. There is no other option,” an airline insider remarked, pointing to losses being incurred by the airline.

High fuel prices, along with airspace closures, have dented the airline's financial performance. Air India's Europe and US flights are now taking extra hours due

FPIs pull out ₹8,731 cr from equities, turn net sellers for the week

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) turned net sellers of Indian equities during the week ended September 4, pulling out ₹8,731.33 crore (\$ 917.05 million), reversing a two-month buying streak seen in July and August, according to data compiled by the National Securities Depository Ltd (NSDL).

“FIIs were net sellers for three sessions during last week, including the quarterly MSCI index rebalancing session on August 31. While DIIs were net buyers in all five sessions during last week,” said Pabitra Mukherjee, Deputy Vice-President-Research, Bajaj Broking, stating that the market remained volatile on the back of rising global oil prices and evolving US-Iran geopolitical tensions.

The equity sell-off was led by heavy outflows on September 1, when FPIs net sold shares worth ₹5,432.83 crore, followed by further selling of ₹953.84 crore on September 3 and ₹2,820.66 crore on September 4. FPIs briefly turned buyers on September 2, infusing ₹1,764.20 crore, while the week had begun with a net outflow of ₹1,288.20 crore on August 31.

Across all asset classes tracked by NSDL, equity, debt, hybrid instruments, mutual funds and Alternative Investment Funds (AIFs), FPIs recorded a combined net outflow of ₹11,620.81 crore (\$ 1,221.33 million) for the week.

The debt segment saw a combined net outflow of ₹443.80 crore. Within debt, the General Limit category attracted a net inflow of ₹311.51 crore, while the Voluntary Retention Route and Fully Accessible Route

categories recorded net outflows of ₹15.99 crore and ₹739.32 crore, respectively.

Hybrid instruments saw the sharpest reversal, with net outflows of ₹2,545.15 crore for the week, largely on account of a single-day outflow of ₹3,451.63 crore on September 3. Mutual funds were the only segment to post net inflows for the week, at ₹99.47 crore, while AIFs recorded no net activity.

MONTHLY REVERSAL

On a month-to-date basis, up to September 4, FPIs remained net sellers of equities to the tune of ₹7,443 crore, with the overall FPI position across all segments at a net outflow of ₹10,289 crore for September so far, NSDL data showed. This follows net equity inflows of ₹20,200 crore in July and ₹29,631 crore in August.

Nifty closing lower on



four of five sessions and forming a mid-week low before recovering some ground towards the close, Mukherjee said. The Bank Nifty relatively outperformed the benchmark, while broader markets were mixed, with the Nifty Midcap index ending the week lower even as the Nifty Smallcap index closed marginally higher.

Commenting on the trend, VK Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist at Geojit Investments Limited, said the “tapering of the chip trade and the FPIs turning consistent sellers in

BS7 norms open up ₹10,000 cr opportunity for component makers

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai



NEW RULES. Heavy trucks and buses could see the richest incremental content at ₹75,000-1 lakh per vehicle

sultations were nearing completion.

“The draft should come in a couple of months,” he said.

Exhaust and after-treatment systems are estimated to capture the largest slice of the BS7 opportunity, about 40-45 per cent, or ₹3,000-4,500 crore, followed by sensors and monitoring controls at 25-30 per cent, or ₹2,000-3,000 crore. Fluid-dosing systems could represent another 15-20 per cent, or ₹1,200-2,000 crore, and precision engine and valve hardware 10-15 per cent, or ₹800-1,500 crore.

“The annual incremental opportunity for the component industry is directionally possible if BS7 requires the expected step-up in after-treatment, sensors, dosing and electronic controls across major vehicle categories,” said Randheer Singh of ForeSee Advisors.

“The value addition will not be uniform: heavy commercial vehicles and diesel passenger vehicles could see the largest increase per vehicle, while two-wheelers could become significant because of their volumes,” Singh said.

That puts Sharda Motor Industries and Tenneco Clean Air India among the more direct beneficiaries through exhaust and after-treatment as-

semblies, alongside Eberspacher and Cummins in heavy-duty applications. Bosch, Uno Minda, Continental and Sensata have exposure to the sensors and monitoring opportunity.

Diesel-heavy portfolios such as that of Mahindra and Tata Motors, alongside offerings from Hyundai, Kia and Toyota, are higher-value applications for suppliers.

Singh said the final opportunity would depend particularly on real-driving emissions, onboard monitoring and the treatment of two-wheelers.

SWING FACTOR

That makes two-wheelers a key swing factor in the final tally. SIAM, backed by Japanese industry body JAMA, wants the segment kept out of initial real-driving emissions (RDE) testing.

“Deferring RDE for two-wheelers could push back a sizable portion of the incremental sensor, monitoring, and control revenue linked to the segment,” experts noted, tracking the natural rollout of BS7.

BS7 will overlap with tighter CAFE III fuel-economy requirements and India's shift to WLTP emissions testing from April 2027.

Defence council to discuss 40 SU-30MKI overhaul

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

The Defence Acquisition Council (DAC), headed by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, is slated to take up multiple projects for clearance during its Monday meeting, including on the routine overhaul of 40 SU-30MKI fighter jets which are the mainstay of the Air Force (IAF) fleet.

The proposal of Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd (HAL) for overhaul of 40 SU-30MKI aircraft, which are of Soviet origin, has come for DAC approval owing to the involvement of a sizeable cost which, if it exceeds a certain level, has to be cleared by the Council, sources privy to development said without sharing the value.

OTHER PROPOSALS

Last year, 20 SU-30MKI fighters were identified for overhaul and the cost was met by HAL itself, sources explained.

India has an operational fleet of close to 260 such jets, also known as Sukhoi.

The Ministry of Defence had awarded the contract to HAL for production of 12 SU-30MKIs at a cost of ₹13,500 crores in December 2024. Besides this, proposals from the Army, the Navy and the Air Force will also be taken up.

NOTICE FOR PUBLICATION

Office of the Deputy Commissioner & District Magistrate, Bengaluru Urban @ Returning Officer for election of the Board of Directors of Indian Co Operative Credit Society Limited

MSCS/CR/77/1998

HEAD OFFICE: 111, 1st Floor, Ganesh Towers, Infantry Road, Bangalore-560001

NOTICE OF ELECTION-2026-27

ELECTION OF BOARD OF DIRECTORS & OFFICE BEARERS

In accordance with Co-operative Election Authority (CEA) Election Order No. 46/2026-27 dated 31 July 2026; election is proposed for the following:

BOARD OF DIRECTORS-09 SEATS

●General-06 ●Scheduled Caste/Scheduled Tribe-01 ●Women-02

Constituencies: Karnataka (1 No), Kerala (1 No), TamilNadu (1 No), Andra Pradesh (1 No), Telangana (1 No), Union Territories (1 No), Scheduled Caste (1 No), Women (2 No)

OFFICE BEARERS-02 SEATS

●Chairman-01 ●Vice-Chairman-01

IMPORTANT ELECTION DATES

Date	Programme
31.08.2026	Notification for election of Branch Development Committee members as delegates for Smaller (Representative) General Body for election of Board of Directors of the Society.
22.09.2026 to 25.09.2026	Selection of delegates representing each branches. Branch wise meeting dates will be published in the website www.iccsl.in and the respective branch notice boards.
28.09.2026	Publication of provisional list of eligible delegates/voters
29.09.2026-05.10.2026	Filing of objections-11.00 AM to 3.00 PM
06.10.2026-08.10.2026	Scrutiny of objections-11.00 AM to 3.00 PM
09.10.2026	Publication of final eligible list
21.10.2026-26.10.2026	Filing of nominations-11.00 AM to 3.00 PM
27.10.2026	Scrutiny of nominations
28.10.2026	Withdrawal-11.00 AM to 3.00 PM; final list by evening
15.11.2026	POLLING, IF NECESSARY-8.00 AM to 4.00 PM
16.11.2026	Counting of votes from 8.00 AM
On or before 20.11.2026	Declaration of Board election result, subject to CEA approval
25.11.2026	Election process for Chairman & Vice-Chairman
26.11.2026	Meeting/election of newly constituted Board
On or before 02.12.2026	Declaration of Office Bearer election result, subject to CEA approval

Election Notice, programme and eligible voter/delegate lists will be published on the Society's website and displayed at the prescribed notice boards/Branch Offices.

Candidates and members are requested to strictly comply with the provisions of the Multi-State Cooperative Societies Act, Rules, CEA directions and applicable election handbooks/instructions.

Sd/-

Chief Executive Officer

Indian Cooperative Credit Society Limited

Sd/-

Returning Officer

For Indian Cooperative Credit Society Limited Elections

MUTHOOTTU MINI NIDHI LIMITED

CIN: U05110KA1996PLC010837
Regd off : No 102, 1st Floor, Copper Arch 83, Infantry Road, Bangalore – 560001, Karnataka

Notice for Annual General meeting

Notice is hereby given that the 36th Annual General Meeting of the shareholders of the M/s. MUTHOOTTU MINI NIDHI LIMITED will be held on Tuesday, 29th September 2026 at 09.30 A.M the registered office of the company situated at No 102, 1stFloor, Copper Arch 83, Infantry Road, Bangalore 560001, Karnataka to consider the following business:

1. To receive, consider and adopt the Audited Balance sheet as at 31st March 2026 and the profit and Loss account for the year ended as on that date together with the schedules and Notes forming part of the Accounts as audited and report by the Auditors of the company and the Directors Report to the shareholders.
2. To appoint Mammen Mathew (DIN:07288499), who retire by rotation and being eligible, offers himself for re- appointment.

Special Business:

3. To regularize the appointment Mr. Jomy Chackochan, (DIN: 11036082), Additional Director, as Director of the company.
4. Approval of Related Party Transactions.

Place: Bangalore, Date : 03.09.2026.

For Muthoottu Mini Nidhi Limited
Sd/- Mathew Muthoottu (DIN: 01786534)
Chairman and Director

Notes:

1. A member entitled to attend and vote at the meeting is entitled to appoint a proxy to attend and vote on a poll instead of himself and such proxy need not be a member of the Company. A person can act as a proxy on behalf of the members not exceeding 50 and holding in aggregate not more than 10% of the total share capital of the company. However, a member holding more than 10% of the total share capital of the company carrying voting rights may appoint a single person as proxy and such person shall not act as proxy for any other person or member.

2. The form of proxy duly stamped and signed must be deposited at the registered office of the company not less than 48 hours before the meeting.
3. Members are requested to notify immediately any change in their address including e-mail address to the Registered Office of the Company.

4. Annual Financial Statements with its enclosures as at 31 March 2026 can be inspected at the registered office of the company, and the financial statements with enclosures are affixed in the Notice Board of the company

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CM V K M BG-BGE

QUICKLY.

NMDC to start commercial coal production next quarter



New Delhi: State-owned NMDC will start the commercial production of thermal coal by the October-December period and looks to sell around 1 mt of the dry fuel within FY27, said Chairman Amitava Mukherjee. In an interview, Mukherjee said the company had drawn a road map up to 2030 to diversify its mining operations to support the government's vision of Viksit Bharat. "Right now, we are 99.9 per cent an iron ore company. We aim to help the growing industries in the country with a maximum of their mineral needs," he said, adding that this year the company will begin the commercial mining of thermal coal and targets to sell a maximum of 1 mt of the commodity to potential buyers.

FCNR(B)-led rupee rally makes gold cheaper, weighs on prices

COST CUSHION. Domestic silver prices also dip, bringing some relief to jewellery buyers

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

After the relentless rally, spot gold prices have fallen by ₹7,270 per 10 g, or four per cent in the last eight trading sessions, to ₹1,54,884 on Friday against ₹162,154 logged on August 26, due to the sharp appreciation of the rupee against the dollar. The rupee appreciated against the dollar by 1 per cent to 94.49 on Friday against 95.35 on August 26 on the back of the \$127 billion mop-up through the FCNR(B) deposits. When rupee appreciates, the value of dollar-denominated gold depreciates and it makes the yellow metal cheaper for consumers in rupee terms. However, any sharp dip in gold makes con-

PRICE RETREAT

- Spot gold prices have fallen by 4% in the last eight trading sessions to ₹1,54,884 on Friday
- Silver prices have also fallen by ₹9,935 per kg to ₹2,35,456

sumers cut down on purchases in anticipation of a further fall in prices. Domestic silver prices also dipped four per cent or ₹9,935 per kg to ₹2,35,456 on Friday from ₹2,45,391 logged on August 24, according to the India Bullion and Jewellers Association data. In the US, spot gold prices fell 3 per cent from \$4,654 an ounce registered on August 26 to \$4,523 an ounce on Friday. Prithviraj Kothari, Presid-

ent, India Bullion and Jewellers Association, said that many consumers prefer to wait rather than buy gold during such periods of uncertainty, and this leads to the bunching up of purchases around perceived dips. SOFTEN GOLD PRICE A steadier or stronger rupee, in turn, softens the domestic price of gold somewhat, since a large part of India's gold is imported and priced

based on the USD-INR conversion. This could offer some relief to jewellery buyers already contending with elevated global gold prices, he said. The overall footfall likely holds up reasonably well, but average ticket size and gold volume per purchase could see a mild dip if volatility persists. Rajesh Rokde, Chairman, All India Gem and Jewellery Domestic Council, said the fall in prices should overall help gold demand during the upcoming festive season, with the industry continuing to encourage responsible consumption, transparency and value creation. Even as the prices may remain volatile, people buy gold for weddings, festivals, auspicious occasions and as a form of long-term wealth

and security for the future, he said. **FESTIVE DEMAND** Aarav Bafna, Director, Akoirah by Augmont, said volatile gold prices were making festive demand more selective rather than smaller in value as consumers continue to prioritise weddings and auspicious purchases. If prices settle after the recent volatility, deferred demand should return relatively quickly, particularly during weddings and the main festive buying days, he added. Supriya Kataria, Founder, Kumari Fine Jewellery, said FCNR(B) deposit flows could certainly provide a favourable backdrop for jewellery consumption, particularly during the festive and wedding season.

GST Council meeting postponed to October 7

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi



The wait for the GST Council meeting has got longer as the 57th meeting has now been postponed to October 7 from September 12. The meeting will be held in Delhi. Confirming the development, government sources did not give a reason for the change, but it is understood that this has been done because of the BRICS Summit 2026, which will be held at Bharat Mandapam on the 12th and 13th of this month. The Delhi government has already declared September 11 a holiday for all government offices, autonomous bodies and public sector undertakings under itself in view of the BRICS Summit and arrangements connected with it. Educational institutions, too, will be closed. The last GST Council meeting took place on September 3 last year. The rules say that there should be at least one meeting every quarter, but there have been delays and this time it is the longest wait on account of various reasons, including Assembly polls in various States. The Council is chaired by the Finance Minister, while the Minister of State in the Finance Ministry and representative Ministers of 28 States and 3 UTs with legislature are members.

FOCUS AREAS Although the agenda of the meeting is yet to be finalised and circulated, this time the focus is likely to be more on compliance and ease of doing business. For example, one likely proposal is finalising the guidelines to bring uniformity in documents that are to be submitted for faster processing of GST registration applications of businesses who pass on tax credit of over ₹2.5 lakh a month. The guidelines are also ex-

pected to prescribe the norms for cancellation. This will be another big reform after the simplified registration process was initiated, based on a recommendation by the GST Council on September 3 last year and rolled out from November 1. It was mainly for small and low-risk businesses. Small and low-risk business applicants whom the GST system identifies based on data analysis or those applicants who self-assess that their output tax liability does not exceed ₹2.5 lakh per month (inclusive of CGST, SGST/UTGST and IGST) can opt for the scheme. Nearly 65 per cent of the GST registrations are happening through this route. Now, the effort is to bring a simplified mechanism for the remaining 35 per cent, who are basically big businesses.

There is a big issue about accumulated compensation cess. The matter is now pending in the Supreme Court. A petition filed by the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations challenged the Centre's notifications on transition or refund of accumulated GST compensation cess credit that industry associations have repeatedly estimated to be around ₹2,500 crore in value. Since the announcement of GST 2.0, auto retailers requested the government to hold validly availed compensation cess balances in their electronic credit ledgers before the new GST regime kicked off on September 22, 2025.

Subhash Chandra's own words contradict claim over Delhi bungalow: Canara Bank

Ankita Upadhyay
New Delhi

Canara Bank, in its appeal before the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT), has pointed to what it says is a contradiction in Subhash Chandra's stand. The ₹1,260-crore sale of a 2.8-acre Bhagwan Das Road property raises a larger question about Chandra's claim that his personal estate is worth only around ₹31.8 crore, and that he has little left to offer creditors. In his response to Canara Bank, Chandra said the property belonged to Greatway Estates Ltd and not to him, and that he neither sold it nor re-

ceived the sale proceeds. Yet, his own repayment plan says he "procured" Greatway Estates to sell the property and use ₹774 crore of the proceeds to discharge liabilities of the principal borrowers and the personal guarantor. As of now, the specific NCLT order Canara Bank appealed against has itself been stayed by a larger NCLT bench, and both the NCLT (fresh hearing) and the NCLAT (the pending appeal) have live proceedings running in parallel. **CHANDRA'S ARGUMENT** Chandra said it is owned by Greatway Estates Ltd and mortgaged to JC Flowers Asset Reconstruction Company Ltd.



Subhash Chandra

He argued that Canara Bank's application rested on "an unverified media report" and that the allegation that he had sold the property or received any consideration was "baseless and unsupported by any factual foundation". The Tribunal accepted

this position. It held that a newspaper report, without independent documentary evidence establishing ownership, sale or receipt of money, could not by itself justify a forensic enquiry, and it declined to take the matter further. Canara Bank's appeal argued that this denial cannot be squared with Chandra's own repayment plan, the document he himself submitted to the resolution professional setting out how he proposed to settle with his creditors. The appeal quotes that plan directly; it records that "the Personal Guarantor has procured" that Greatway Estates "will sell the property at 4, Bhagwan Das Road" and use the pro-

ceeds "for payment of ₹774 crore" toward releasing shares pledged to World Crest Advisors LLP, one of the creditor entities that voted in favour of his repayment plan. The bank's case is that this is, in effect, an admission in his own hand: A person who has "procured" a company to sell its most valuable asset and has personally directed hundreds of crores of the proceeds cannot also claim to have no connection to that asset. The appeal calls this "absolute, de facto authority" over the company and adds two further points: That Greatway Estates has a paid-up capital of only ₹5 lakh, and that its registered ad-

ministrative email address is on the Essel Group's domain, both cited by the bank as signs that Greatway is not the independent entity Chandra described it as. Chandra's position through the insolvency proceedings so far has been that the company — and not he personally — owned and sold the property, and that no sale proceeds passed through his hands. The bank's fresh argument, that his own repayment plan contradicts that position, is now before the NCLAT, which has yet to rule on it. Mehta then withdrew the request, and the NCLAT kept the appeal pending, adjourning it to October 7, 2026.

TODAY'S PICK.

HEG (₹729.05): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

The stock of HEG has been in an uptrend since April 2023. While there have been intermittent corrections in price, the broader direction remained up. Last month, it broke out a resistance at ₹680 and hit a multi-year high of ₹753.90 on September 1. That said, in recent sessions, the stock has been trading flat. However, it has now formed a higher base at ₹700. Below this is another support at ₹675. We anticipate a recovery on the back of the ₹675-700 support band. Once the rally begins, the stock could



Indian Bank to set up office in Dubai

Press Trust of India
Chennai

Indian Bank has received board approval to open a representative office in Dubai as it seeks to expand its overseas operations, leveraging the large Indian diaspora across West Asia. Currently, the bank has a full-service international branch in Singapore and branches in Colombo and Jaffna (Sri Lanka). Besides, it has an IFSC Banking Unit (IBU) functioning as an offshore/foreign branch from GIFT City, Gandhinagar. "We are getting good business from our GIFT City branch, including participa-



Binod Kumar, MD & CEO, Indian Bank

tion in various syndicated loans... My aim now is to open a rep office in Dubai... We have a good number of non-resident Indians settled in Dubai and about 33 per cent of the working population is Indian," Indian Bank MD and CEO Binod Kumar said in an interaction. For the representative office in Dubai, the bank's board has given its approval and the bank is in the process of seeking other regulatory approvals. Besides, Kumar said, the bank is exploring the possibility of having a presence in Malaysia and Indonesia.

We are looking at opportunities to enter the tokenised assets market in India: Equiniti CEO

bl.interview

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Fresh off its acquisition by global digital assets enterprise Bullish, global transfer agent Equiniti is exploring the tokenised assets space in India as the regulators signal openness. Equiniti serves about 55 per cent of FTSE 100 firms in the UK and 35 per cent of S&P 500 companies in the US, and its global operations and tech centre are based out of Chennai and Bengaluru. While automation slows headcount growth, Dan Kramer, CEO, Equiniti, says India teams are building critical global products and more work will continue to happen here. Kramer has over 30 years of experience across financial services organisations like Morgan Stanley, Merrill Lynch, Deutsche Bank, JP Morgan and BNY. Edited excerpts: **How large is Equiniti's business today?** We keep the record of ownership for 3,000 public companies. We have, in the UK, about 55 per cent of the FTSE 100 listed companies

as clients and in the US, about 35 per cent of the S&P 500. We are number two in the US, number one in the UK. Besides shareholder services, we also have a share plan business, and a business called Notified, which is about community investor relations and public relations. **Tell us about the India footprint of Equiniti.** India has been the operations and technology centre for us. We've grown from a few hundred people [in 2014-15] to 2,600 people today. This is also a hub for our finance services and HR teams. Pretty much every function in the company has a presence here in India. We have members of our global leadership team here in India, and as we increase automation, a lot of that work is being led here in India. We began our presence in Chennai 10 years ago and expanded to Bengaluru, and then with the acquisition of Notified recently we also gained a site in Nagercoil. **Equiniti was recently acquired by Bullish. How does that change its work in India?** With more digitisation, there's now a trend to move

With more digitisation, there's now a trend to move towards tokenisation of assets, in general, and specifically of equities **DAN KRAMER, CEO, Equiniti** towards tokenisation of assets in general, and specifically of equities. This led Bullish, which is the largest crypto exchange and digital assets platform, to own and partner with transfer agent. We will be closing the transaction sometime at the end of this year or early next year. We have already started to work with our issuer clients to begin tokenising their shareholder registers. We now have seven customers in the US who have either started to or agreed to tokenise their register, including Bullish itself. A good portion of that work is happening here in India. **Tokenisation has been seen positively by Indian regulators. So, with the Bullish association, will you do**



commercial business in India? Hundred per cent. We're looking at opportunities to enter the tokenised equity market in India. We have the capabilities and expertise within Bullish to tokenise assets beyond just equities. As an example, we think real estate in India is ripe for tokenisation. Over the next year or two, we're going to start looking at all assets in India, not just equities. As you know, the regulatory framework is being developed, but it's not there yet, but the regulators have indicated that they're moving in that direction. **Given the levels of business automation, will the India teams grow?** As we start partnering with Bullish, we'll be moving

more and more work here. But given the automation initiatives and everything else going on, we won't be growing at the same pace as we have for the last 10 years. We'll be growing, but not at that same pace. Everybody is getting more efficient and more effective. So, the future here in India may not be about adding more people, but it will still be about doing more work. We now have about 43 per cent of the entire company workforce in India. **What is key global work for Equiniti happening out of India?** Today, customers care more about how we ingest and distribute their data. If you are querying us, you don't have to go into a website or app or fill out a form. You should be able to just ask a question and get an answer — that's how we're building our systems. This is being made possible by a product called EQ1, which we launched a week ago and is going to be rolled out globally over the next year, and is being built here in India. In case of operational efficiencies, automating internal processes and rolling out our RPAs [Robotic Process Automations] is also being developed here [in India].

SC to hear today plea seeking guidelines to control airfare fluctuations

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday a plea seeking regulatory guidelines to control the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfare and ancillary charges imposed by private airlines in India. As per the court's cause list of September 7, the matter would be heard by a bench comprising Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep

Mehta. On August 17, the Centre had told the top court that it had fast-tracked the framing of rules under the Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam, 2024, which is aimed at modernising the aviation sector, and the same would be finalised within three weeks. The government placed the draft rules before the bench in a sealed cover, saying some final discussions were going on. The top court had noted that Additional Solicitor

General Anil Kaushik, appearing for the Centre, sought three weeks to get the draft rules finalised and place it before the court. **TRANSPARENCY SOUGHT** The court is hearing a plea filed by social activist S Laxminarayanan, who sought a robust and independent regulator that ensures transparency and passenger protection across the civil aviation sector and regulatory guidelines to control the "unpredictable fluctu-

ations" in airfare and ancillary charges imposed by private airlines in India. Senior advocate Ravindra Srivastava, appearing for the petitioner, argued before the bench that till the time the new rules come into force, the old rules are operating. Questioning the "lack of willingness" on the part of the authorities and the effectiveness of the existing mechanism, he argued that airlines were charging exorbitant fares. On July 13, the top court

had asked the Centre to place the rules framed under the Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam, 2024, before it. It said that the rules be placed before it in a sealed cover, irrespective of whether or not those had been placed before Parliament. While hearing the plea on May 15, the apex court said that there should be some rationalisation of airfares, and asked the Central government to provide relief to flyers.

Govt mulls FDI liberalisation in plantation sector

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The government is considering liberalising foreign direct investment (FDI) norms in the plantation sector by bringing more commercial crops under the ambit, an official said. The Commerce Ministry is holding stakeholder consultations on the issue, the official said. "We are looking for more FDI liberalisation in the plantation sector like banana," the official added. At present, 100 per cent FDI under the automatic route is permitted in the tea sector, including in plantations, coffee, rubber, cardamom, palm and olive oil tree plantations. Besides these, FDI is not allowed in any plantation sector/activity. India received \$295.23 million FDI in tea and coffee, and \$3.93 billion in rubber goods during April 2000 and March 2026.

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MoD allocates ₹400 crore for defence diplomacy, plans 90 wings by 2030-end

MIGHTY MOVE. Government nudges defence wings to boost export and international co-operation

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

The Ministry of Defence (MoD) plans to increase its military diplomacy outreach to the entire globe by establishing 85-90 defence wings by the end of 2030. The priority is to place corresponding officers in 12 countries that have already deployed their respective defence attaches in New Delhi. But India has not done this so far.

The defence wings act as forward nodes of defence diplomacy and industry outreach with host nations.

As of now, India has about 54 defence wings in missions abroad, internal MoD information accessed by *businessline* revealed. Of this, two are in the US, 11 in Africa, 10 in Europe, 30 in Asia and two in the Oceania region. Ten more defence wings were approved by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh in 2024, which are in the process of getting established, taking the total to 62.

Of the new wings, three more will be opened in the US, four in Africa, one in Europe and one will be taken out of Asia, as per changes



REGIONAL OUTREACH. India is expanding concessional defence credit to strengthen regional security and capacity

made in the strategy.

Moreover, to facilitate regular dialogue and engagement, instead of opening a new defence office in every single country, accreditation has been given to 50 existing ones to cover neighbouring nations.

This way, the outreach can be expanded to an overall 157 countries, as per the MoD's plan.

DIPLOMACY FUND

The defence diplomacy fund, launched in FY22 with a corpus of ₹110 crore, is drafted into the revenue budget of the Army, the Air Force (IAF) and the Navy. Since FY25, the Coast Guard has been funds to increase India's strategic outreach by way of offering gifts and gratis to friendly foreign countries,

like in Africa, with significant defence material, equipment and infrastructure support.

The fund was increased to ₹150 crore in FY23, and the budget remained the same in FY24, but there was a significant jump to ₹300 crore in FY25 and to ₹400 crore in FY26.

The government is giving a nudge to defence wings and reorienting the role of defence attaches (DAs), who are drawn from the Army, the Navy and the Air Force and posted as diplomats in embassies and consulates abroad, to promote exports and cooperation with countries.

Sources said the DAs have been withdrawn from many countries from which equipment was being imported to those regions and nations to

which India is exporting or has potential for future trade. India has set a defence export target of ₹50,000 crore by 2030, up from ₹38,424 crore in FY26.

Besides this, India is looking to enhance the presence of liaison officers in multinational constructs and host countries in West Africa, the Mediterranean, Latin America, the Caribbean and Pacific Island. As of now, India has positioned 2 international liaison officers for co-operation with organisations and between nations and 4 more will be deputed in the near future, as per the Ministry's blueprint.

Positioning of international liaison officers enables real-time access to policy discussion, intelligence inputs and decision-making processes, allowing India to shape outcomes and provide a faster crisis response.

OTHER MILESTONES

This is in addition to the 'Bharat Maitree Shakti Scheme,' through which New Delhi has increasingly extended dedicated concessional defence lines of credit to boost defence exports, maritime security and capacity building to adjoining

countries like Vietnam, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Mauritius, Maldives and many in the African continent.

The other milestones flagged are by way of defence industrial collaboration, aimed through initiatives like the global shipyard model. This approach also serves as a calibrated response to expanding Chinese maritime influence under the Belt and Road Initiative, with India emphasising transparency, sustainability and capacity building rather than debt-driven engagement, the strategic roadmap reveals.

The model is anchored in the government's massive ₹69,725-crore shipbuilding reform package unveiled late last year. By leveraging partnerships with global leaders like South Korea and Japan, India intends to promote green shipping, aiming for 30 per cent of the fleet to use clean fuels by 2047 and reduce the current \$110 billion annual outflow to foreign vessels.

Minister Rajnath Singh, on September 3, released the 'Raksha' framework, which outlines the roadmap over the next 10 years.

Rentomojo targets growth as rental assets generate repeat revenue

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Rentomojo is taking its rental model to the public markets with a ₹1,256 crore IPO, but the more interesting part of its pitch may be what happens to a sofa or refrigerator after the first customer is done with it.

The company's RHP shows its FY17 asset cohort has generated 5.12 times its original asset cost in revenue as furniture and appliances are refurbished, redeployed and rented out again.

Chairperson, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer Geetansh Bamanian has described this as a model where the business can keep extracting value from the same asset across multiple customer cycles.

The IPO, opening on September 9, comprises ₹150 crore of fresh capital and ₹1,106 crore of an offer for sale, valuing the company at about ₹4,246 crore at the upper end of the price band.

"We did not have a primary need for capital," Bamanian told *businessline*, adding that the IPO would partly reduce the company's cost of capital by repaying higher-cost debt.

ASSET OCCUPANCY

Its asset occupancy stood around 83-84 per cent in



Geetansh Bamanian, Chairperson, MD and CEO, Rentomojo

FY26. Rentomojo's operating revenue rose 45.5 per cent to ₹387 crore in FY26, while profit after tax more than doubled to ₹104.3 crore from the ₹43.1 crore a year earlier.

"Whenever we grow rapidly, there can be some pressure on the EBITDA margin," Bamanian said, describing Rentomojo as a "front-ended cash flow business" because delivery, repair and maintenance costs

are incurred upfront when an asset is deployed.

That makes asset productivity increasingly important as the company expands beyond its established markets.

NEWER MARKET

Rentomojo had 2.54 lakh live subscribers across 29 cities as of March 2026. Yet its revenue remains heavily concentrated: 98.19 per cent of FY26 operating revenue came from furniture and appliance rentals, while its top 10 cities accounted for 89.51 per cent of revenue, according to the RHP.

The company is also entering markets such as Indore and Lucknow, partly following customers who relocated there. The challenge, however, will be to replicate its asset economics as it moves into newer markets without having to disproportionately increase inventory, warehouse and logistics costs.



Malabar Regional Co-operative Milk Producers' Union Ltd.
Head Office, Peringolam, Kunnamangalam, Kozhikode-673 571, Kerala
Website: www.milmaunion.com, E-mail: mrcpm@milmaunion.com
From 0495-2655407, 420, Mobile No: 9198180266

No. MRU/ ENGG/Tender Advt/2026-27/ 05.09.2026

TENDER NOTICE

Tenders are invited from eligible bidders through e-procurement window of Government of Kerala (www.etenders.kerala.gov.in) for the following work.

Item	Closing Date & Time
Interior works of New HO, MRCMPU Ltd	28.09.2026 10.00 AM
E-tender ID: 2026_KCMMF_866991_1	

For further enquiries, visit our website or contact Head Office, MRCMPU Ltd.
Managing Director

As coal reserves fall, more TPPs left with critical stocks

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Coal stocks at thermal power plants (TPPs) have fallen nearly 29 per cent in just over a month, from 38 million tonnes (mt) at the end-July to 27.14 mt on September 4 as supply disruptions coincide with sustained power demand.

The number of plants with critical coal stocks has also risen from 51 to 57 in just five days, indicating that roughly one-third of the cumulative operating coal-based capacity of roughly 224 gigawatts (GW) is now carrying critical supplies.

According to the latest Coal and Power Ministry data, the number of plants with critical stocks rose to 57 on September 4, up from 51 on August 31. At the end of July 2026, TPPs had 38 mt of coal stocks, which declined to 29.12 mt at the end of August and further to 27.14 mt on September 4.

DECLINE REASONS

A major reason for the decline in stocks at the TPP end is that historically, supplies get stretched during monsoon, as rains hinder mining activity and transport.

Thermal power plants with critical coal stocks				
	DCB plants	ICB plants	Washery rejects	Total stocks (MT)
August 31	46	4	1	29.12
September 1	40	4	1	28.64
September 2	45	4	1	28.17
September 3	50	4	1	27.59
September 4	52	4	1	27.14

Source: National Power Portal; DCB: Domestic Coal Based Plants; ICB: Imported Coal Based Plants; Washery Rejects: Plants based on Washery coal rejects; Total Stocks: Cumulative Coal Stocks at Plant-end Pan-India.

Another reason is that TPPs are burning more coal due to the high power demand since April, which has stretched into August as high heat and humidity is pushing up cooling demand.

For instance, energy consumption in July was around 171 billion units (BU) — the highest on record for any month — driven by a spurt in usage of cooling equipment, amid a rainfall deficit triggered by El Nino, according to Crisil Intelligence.

Rising electricity demand during evening and night hours, due to more than the average maximum and minimum temperature and humidity, has pushed up buy bids on power exchanges.

For instance, the Indian Energy Exchange (IEX) recorded a monthly electricity traded volume of 13,527 BUs in July 2026.

The frantic buying activity

also pushed up prices. The average market clearing price (MCP) in the Day-Ahead Market at the IEX stood at ₹4.88 per unit in August, a 22 per cent y-o-y increase.

Similarly, the average MCP in the real-time market stood at ₹4.41 a unit, registering a 30.4 per cent y-o-y growth.

MINISTRY'S RESPOND

Media reports pointed out that stretched coal supplies at TPPs in Punjab had forced the Coal Ministry to respond.

"The Ministry of Coal clarifies that adequate coal has been made available to Punjab's power plants, and Coal India remains fully committed to ensuring uninterrupted coal supply for power generation across the country, including in the State of Punjab," the Ministry added.

FSSAI suspends licences of Kailash Formulation, Sanecure Water

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has suspended the licences of West Bengal-based Kailash Formulation and Sanecure Water Project after uncovering severe violations of hygiene, sanitation and compliance standards.

"Enforcement drives led to the suspension of FSSAI licences for Kailash Formulation and Sanecure Water Project due to severe violations of hygiene, sanitation and compliance standards," it said in a social media post.

Packaged drinking water company Sanecure Water Project's licence was suspended for contraventions and major violations of regulations, it said.

"Poor hygiene and sanitation, inadequate pest-proofing and significant pest infestation were observed, raising serious concerns over food safety," it said.

For Kailash Formulations, overall hygiene and sanitation of the premises were found to be unsatisfactory, it added. Non-compliance in packaging and raw materials was also observed, the food safety regulator noted.

Hiring decisions pick up speed, but long notice periods creating a new recruitment bottleneck

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Indian companies are moving faster to close hiring decisions, but long notice periods and a growing shortage of specialised talent are making it harder to get people on board quickly, creating a new bottleneck between making an offer and having the employee join, according to hiring experts.

According to CareerNet data, the time from raising a requisition to extending an offer fell from 53 days in FY25 to 46 days in FY26, an improvement in how fast companies are closing roles. Notice periods, however, have barely changed.

The average gap between accepting an offer and joining remained around 30-33 days across both years. Roughly 29-31 per cent of the hires still took 60 days or more to join after accepting an offer.

"Nearly a third of hires take two months or longer to join after accepting an offer

Recruitment timeline				
City / seniority	Notice Period (no. of days)		Time-to-hire (no. of days)	
	FY26	FY25	FY26	FY25
NCR	38	28	43.5	56
Hyderabad	35	33	47	67
Bengaluru	33	33	43	46
Chennai	29	24	60	52
Mumbai	30.5	36	43	49
Pune	22	43.5	48	63
0-3 years	33	33	38	42
3-7 years	31	31	50	59
7-12 years	33	38	49.5	57
12+ years	41	43.5	40	56

Source: CareerNet

— a significant gap between making the hiring decision and the person coming on board. During that period, companies are also managing the risk of counteroffers, drop-offs or losing the candidate to another opportunity," Neelabh Shukla, Chief Business Officer, CareerNet, explained.

In a competitive talent market, this puts more pressure on hiring teams to consider availability, alongside skills and fit. A candidate who can join sooner may have an advantage when two

candidates are otherwise comparable.

TURNAROUND TIME

Meanwhile, Adecco noted that in its flexi staffing business, the turnaround time expected by clients had come down to 24 hours. Notice periods continue to range from 30 to 90 days, with 90 days being common for senior hires.

In CareerNet's placements, hiring volume for AI, machine learning and data science roles grew by about 48 per cent y-o-y. The aver-

age time-to-hire for these roles increased from 38 days to 63 days. Employers are opening more AI-related positions, but taking longer to close them.

CAREERNET DATA

As per CareerNet data, GCCs' average time-to-hire is 37-38 days, as opposed to non-GCC employers at 54-65 days. However, they face a challenge after the offer is made. GCCs have the longest notice-period wait, at 41-42 days compared with 27-28 days for non-GCC companies. They are also the only segment where the share of hires taking 60 days or more to join increased y-o-y, from 35.7 per cent to 36.5 per cent.

Ganesh S Padmanabhan, VP, Recruitment Business at CIEL HR, said, "Long notice periods add friction when global companies are competing for a limited pool of experienced specialists. They do not, by themselves, undermine India's competitiveness, but they can slow execution."



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CIN L25199KL1993PLC007018

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NOTICE OF THE 33RD ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING (AGM) ON 29TH SEPTEMBER, 2026 AT 11.00 A.M.

Notice is hereby given that the 33rd Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the Members of Rubfila International Limited ("Company") (CIN: L25199KL1993PLC007018) to be held on Tuesday, 29th September, 2026 at 11.00 AM through Video Conferencing ("VC") / Other Audio Visual Means ("OVAM"), in compliance with General Circular No.14/2020 dt.08/04/2020, General Circular No.17/2020 dt.13/04/2020, Circular No.20/2020 dt.05/05/2020, Circular No.02/2021 dt.13.01.2021, Circular No. 02/2022 dt. 05/05/2022, Circular No.09/2023 dated September 25, 2023 and Circular No. 09/2024 dated September 19, 2024 and all other applicable laws and circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA), Government of India and Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 read with Circular No. SEBI/HO/CFD/CMD1/CIR/P/2020/79, SEBI/HO/CFD/CMD2/CIR/P/2021/11 and SEBI/HO/CFD/CMD2/CIR/P/2022/62 dt. 12th May,2020, 15th January, 2021 and 13th May, 2022, 5th January 2023, 03rd October 2024 respectively issued by Security Exchange Board of India ("SEBI Circulars"), allowing the Companies to conduct the AGM through VC/OVAM, to transact the business as set out in the notice of Annual General Meeting, which has been sent in permitted mode to all shareholders. The AGM notice and other documents are available on the Company's website, www.rubfila.com, the website of Central Depository Services (India) Limited (CDSL) at www.evotingindia.com and the website of the Bombay Stock Exchange Limited at www.bseindia.com and the website of National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com

In compliance with Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 and with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, as amended, and Regulation 44 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, the Company is providing the Members the facility to exercise their right to vote by electronic means and the business may be transacted through remote e-voting services provided by CDSL.

Shareholders holding shares either in physical form or dematerialized form, as on the cut-off date Tuesday, 22th September 2026, may cast their votes electronically on the business as set forth in the Notice of the AGM through the electronic voting system ("remote e-voting"), the details of which are given below:

A	Statement on businesses to be transacted by electronic voting.	Business set out in Notice dated 20th August, 2026, may be transacted by electronic voting
B	Date of completion of sending notice of AGM	05th September 2026
C	Cut-off date for determining the eligibility to vote by remote voting or e- voting at AGM	Tuesday, 22nd September 2026
D	Date and time of commencement of remote e-voting	Saturday, 26th September 2026 (9.00 AM)
E	Date time of ending of remote e-voting	Monday, 28th September 2026 (5.00 PM)
F	The remote e-voting module shall be disabled by CDSL after 5:00 p.m. IST on Monday, 28th September 2026 and once the votes on a resolution is cast by the shareholder, the shareholder will not be allowed to change it subsequently.	
G	Website details of the Company/Agency, where the Notice of AGM is displayed.	www.rubfila.com
H	Contact details of the person responsible to address the grievances connected with electronic voting and technical assistance to access and participate in the meeting through VC.	Mr. Rakesh Dalvi, Sr. Manager, (CDSL) Central Depository Services (India) Limited, A Wing, 25 th Floor, Marathon Futurex, Mafatal Mill Compounds, N M Joshi Marg, Lower Parel (East), Mumbai - 400013 or send an email to helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com or call toll free no. 1800 22 55 33.

Any person, who acquires shares of the company and becomes a shareholder post-dispatch of the Notice of the AGM and holds shares as on the cut-off date i.e. Tuesday, 22nd September 2026, may obtain the login ID and password by sending a request to helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com. However, if a person is already registered with CDSL for e-voting, then the existing user ID and password can be used for casting their vote. Any person who is not a shareholder / ceased to be a shareholder as on the cut-off date should treat this notice for information purpose only.

The notice of the AGM will be made available on the Company's website, at www.rubfila.com under "Annual Report" section, website of the stock exchanges viz., BSE Limited at https://www.bseindia.com/ , National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com and on the CDSL website, at www.evotingindia.com.

Shareholders may note that:

- The facility for e-voting will be made available during the AGM, and those shareholders present in the AGM through VC/OVAM facility, shall be eligible to vote through the e-voting system at the AGM.
- Any Member, who has already exercised his votes through remote e-voting, may attend the Meeting but will not be permitted to vote at the Meeting and his/her vote, if any, cast at the Meeting shall be treated as invalid.
- Only persons whose names are recorded in the register of members or in the register of beneficial owners maintained by the depositories as on the cut-off date shall be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-voting at the AGM.
- The voting right of shareholders shall be in proportion to their share in the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on the cut-off date, being Tuesday, 22nd September 2026.
- The shareholders can join the AGM in the VC/OVAM mode 15 minutes before the scheduled time of the commencement of the Meeting by using the remote e-voting login credentials and by following the procedure mentioned in this Notice. The facility to join through VC/OVAM will be available for shareholders on first come first serve basis.

Shareholders will have an opportunity to cast their vote through the e-voting system during the meeting on the business as may be set forth in the Notice of the AGM through electronic voting system. The manner of voting remotely for shareholders holding shares in dematerialized mode, physical mode and for shareholders who have not registered their email addresses will be provided in the Notice of the AGM.

CS. Sreekumar P.S., Partner, M/s. SVJS & Associates, Company Secretaries, Kochi has been appointed as Scrutinizer for conducting the e-voting process in a fair and transparent manner. The results of the voting will be announced by the Company on its website www.rubfila.com and the website of CDSL www.evotingindia.com and will also be intimated to BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited.

Shareholders may please note that, in terms of the aforementioned circulars, the Company will not be sending physical copies of AGM Notice to the shareholders.

Shareholders holding shares in physical form are requested to register their email addresses with the Share Transfer Agents of the Company M/s. Integrated Registry Management Services Private Limited at their email address: einward@integratedindia.in by submitting the Form ISR-1 and the Form ISR-2 could be downloaded from the website of RTA at forms download option under the link https://www.integratedregistry.in /KYCRegister.aspx. Those holding shares in demat form are requested to register their email IDS with their Depository Participants.

By Order of the Board of Directors
RUBFILA INTERNATIONAL LTD
Sd/-
N.N.Parameswaran
Chief Finance Officer & Company Secretary

Palakkad
05.09.2026

PREMIER
TISSUES



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Bond blues

Rising global yields, high public debt are worrisome

The surging bond yields in major developed markets across the world are sending an unmistakable message — the era of financial repression that began after the global financial crisis (GFC) is finally over. Interest costs or the cost of capital will now increasingly be based on demand and supply and not by artificial suppression of rates.



Ignoring this message will come with painful consequences, both for some of the global central bankers who have failed in their inflation mandates, or governments that run persistently high fiscal deficits. While the current high 10-year government bond yields — at around 4.75 per cent in the US, 2.90 per cent in Japan, 5.15 per cent in the UK, 3.35 per cent in Germany, and 4.2 per cent in France — were the norm in pre-GFC era, the crucial difference and complication lies in the balance sheets. Since 2007 to now, the government debt-to-GDP has soared from roughly 65 per cent to 124 per cent in the US, 150 per cent to 207 per cent in Japan, 43 per cent to 102 per cent in the UK, and 66 per cent to 116 per cent in France. As borrowing costs rise due to higher yields across tenors, spiraling interest expense in itself adds to the fiscal burden. Such bond yields have been dealt with in the past, but not at current levels of debt. Compounding the problem is an erosion of institutional credibility. For example the US Fed has failed in its inflation mandate for 64 consecutive months.

Governments continue to stick to expansionary fiscal policies and have increasingly resorted to interventions in the markets to address issues stemming from these — like the US treasury recently announcing plans to increase buybacks of 30-year bonds as yields surged to a 19-year high, or the rare synchronised, coordinated intervention by the US and Japan to halt the decline in Japanese yen against the USD when it was hovering at 40-year lows against the latter. These quick-fixes cannot work when the fundamentals do not change; long-dated yields remain elevated, and currency pressures in Japan persist. Market forces are sending a strong message and authorities need to take heed. Central banks must regain credibility — much like what Paul Volcker achieved in the early 1980s — and governments must curb fiscal excess before markets force their hand, as the UK gilt crisis demonstrated in 2022.

As for India, increasing cost of capital globally can affect inflows into the country as already witnessed in the case of net FII flows in the last two years. Further, reducing yield differentials between the US and India's 10-year yield, which is at around 215 basis points now, needs to be watched. While it is above the low of 165 basis points in May 2025, it can trend lower as US yields continue to increase. Lower yield differential can make Indian bonds less attractive to foreign investors given risk of currency volatility too. Reserve Bank of India will need to maintain a vigilant stance on inflation to avoid currency pressures, while remaining alert to spillover risks should developed market yields spike further.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

Nigel Farage has questions to answer
Reform UK's conference was to open showcasing a party ready for government. It did so with two top aides removed after an investigation aired on Channel 4, its finances under police scrutiny and seven in 10 voters, polls suggest, regarding its leader, Nigel Farage, as sleazy – double the number who thought the same of Andy Burnham. Reform, a rightwing populist party, says it will take power back from a corrupt establishment. The latest scandal raises a question: does Reform oppose the influence of big money – or just who benefits from it? Undercover reporters from Verbatim Investigations, founded by journalists from the Centre for Climate Reporting, pretended to be a wealthy American father and his UK-based son who wanted to donate to Reform. In the UK, foreign donations are banned from politics. LONDON, SEPTEMBER 4

讀賣新聞

Can Deterrence Be Maintained in Asia?
U.S. aircraft carriers, which carry many fighter jets, are a symbol of the massive military power of the United States. If aircraft carriers continue to be absent from East Asia for an extended period, this could weaken deterrence, raising serious concerns. In response to the situation involving Iran, the U.S. aircraft carrier George Washington of the U.S. 7th Fleet, whose home port is Yokosuka Naval Base in Kanagawa Prefecture, has been deployed to the Middle East since mid-August. The carrier ship was sent to the region to relieve the aircraft carrier Abraham Lincoln. The Abraham Lincoln was originally scheduled to return to the United States in May but remained in the Middle East due to the prolonged attacks against Iran. TOKYO, SEPTEMBER 6

Party appeal vs candidate risk

Just ideology or a popular leader can't fully eliminate candidate risk in elections

LINE& LENGTH.
TCA SRINIVASA RAGHAVAN

While others were getting worked up over a former finance secretary's mischievous pronouncement on the latest GDP figures, I was reading a post by someone altogether more responsible: the Nobel winner Paul Krugman on the US bond market.

He was discussing it with another professor from the Massachusetts Institute of Technology. At one point they discussed what happened with, and to, the highly risky, subprime loans.

Krugman mentioned something called copulas, a term I had not heard of. So I googled it and was told that "a copula describes the dependence structure between variables, rather than just the probability of independent events" and further that it "connects individual (marginal) probabilities into a combined picture."

What does this mean? According to Abe Sklar's Theorem, which I had not heard of either, "any joint distribution splits into two pieces: the individual behaviors (marginals) and the dependence between them (the copula)."

Further googling, which is the current term for research, showed that copulas were massively used in the programmes used in the financial markets in the West in the period leading up to the crisis of 2008 to model joint risks and extreme events. They might have caused it eventually.

To simplify hugely, for which my apologies, that's basically what bundling of risky assets was all about. You combined various probabilities and got a single risk probability for the entire package.

The method used was something called a 'Gaussian copula'. Google told me it "combines different probability distributions into a single joint distribution by capturing the correlation between variables."

But there was a problem which was ignored: what if there were a few probabilities that were way off the



POLL CONNECT. Choosing winnable candidates is a tricky task for all political parties THULASI KAKKAT

mean? And that's exactly what happened by September 2008. The whole thing collapsed and we got the Atlantic Financial Crisis whose effects are still being felt.

POLITICS AND COPULAS
I will not stretch the analogy too far because that would be ridiculous. But it occurred to me that the question of joint probabilities could be important in the context of politics also because political parties combine the risks in individual candidates and come up with consolidated assessments of their chances of winning X or Y or Z number of seats, a kind of Gaussian copula, if you like.

The BJP for example believes that, as a party, it can definitely win between 220-240 seats. That's like a normal distribution with most of its candidates

The real task is to identify and accept high tail risk. This becomes hard when there is competition within a party to distribute patronage

falling under the bell. But what of the tails of this distribution?

This can become of critical importance if there are too many candidates with extreme risks. They would lie at the tails of the distribution. It is easy to get an idea of their riskiness by looking at the winning and losing margins.

So consider: of the 543 candidates chosen to contest an election, even if 20 per cent fall in this category, where the margins are small, the BJP could lose nearly 108 seats. Something like that may well have happened in 2024 when it lost 63 seats, of which 33 were in UP. Poor candidate selection, rather than any lofty reason like the rumoured abolition of reservations, could have been the reason.

The same thing applies to all political parties. They all can, and do, choose candidates with high risks of losing for whatever local reason.

CANDIDATE RISK
The Congress is a case in point and it should look into this if it wants to increase its Lok Sabha strength. Is it choosing its candidates badly? In Gaussian terms, is the tail demolishing the dog?

Back in 2014, Rahul Gandhi tried to reform the ticket distribution method by choosing candidates via the American primaries process, which is basically "may the most popular person get the ticket". It was a great initiative because it sought to minimise tail risk.

But it failed spectacularly. The Congress went from 207 seats in 2009 to just 44 in 2014. There are many theories about why this happened but no one questions either the need or the method used to minimise candidate risk. Rahul then gave up the reform.

A very popular party leader like Indira Gandhi or Narendra Modi can be used to mitigate some of the high risk. People then vote for that leader rather than the candidate.

The problem lies, however, in (a) the popular leader no longer being able to mitigate the risk sufficiently and (b) in choosing too many high-risk candidates, hoping for the best. This is why at least a quarter or more of all contestants always lose.

So the real task is to identify and accept high tail risk. This becomes hard when there is competition within a party to distribute patronage because tail risks get underestimated and are reported wrongly to the party high commands.

Ways to deal with FCNR liquidity deluge

For both RBI and banks, there are interesting possibilities and implications

Madan Sabnavis

The deluge of forex into the country on account of the FCNR/OFCEB/ECB scheme has been a blessing. It raises the forex reserves, which in turn looks healthier in terms of import cover. It adds to liquidity in a big way such that there is discussion on how to deal with surpluses.

The final number after the non-FCNR flows are reckoned could well cross \$150 billion after the announced \$137 billion garnered so far. What does it mean to all the parties concerned?

For the RBI, the inflow of \$137 billion means approximately 20 per cent increase in reserves from the level of \$682 billion as of June 5. This can be used for several purposes. First, it can be used for spot interventions in the market as and when required. Second, it can be used to square off forwards books which stood at \$103 billion as of June 30. Third, it can be invested in US treasuries or any other asset as per the policy being pursued. There could be a return of 4.7-5 per cent on these investments depending on the tenure of investment.

There is, however, also a swap cost for the central banks which can be around 3 per cent. With a round ₹13 lakh crore being given to banks for the swap of

\$137 billion, there can be a cost of ₹39,000 crore on an annual basis. This will however be covered by the investments in US treasuries, thus giving a positive net return. This will be positive for the income and expenditure statement.

On the other hand, given a larger balance sheet, the contingency buffer to be maintained increases in value terms, which can counter this increase in revenue. Also, if the RBI sells its holdings of GSec to manage liquidity then the interest earned from them would come down. Hence it needs to be seen if the surplus to the government can be maintained under *ceteris paribus* conditions.

ISSUES FOR BANKS
For banks, the issues will be different. They have procured clean funds at the cost of 6.25-7.25 per cent for five years. This higher amount of ₹13 lakh crore in dollar terms would entail an interest outgo of say ₹87,750 crore. The swap cost of hedging this interest at 3 per cent would be around ₹2,600 crore as this is not covered by the central bank. Now these funds have to be deployed in either lending or investments. Presently the weighted average lending rate on loans is 8.52 per cent for all banks, which means that there can be a spread of about 1.75 per cent, assuming average cost of 6.75



FCNR MOP-UP. Options for banks

per cent. The surplus of ₹13 lakh crore in the system has implications for the markets. These funds would be used to manage the loan book without seeking recourse to bulk deposits or certificates of deposits. Hence these two markets will get depressed.

Increasing the CRR through an incremental CRR may not be fair for banks which have not been aggressive in collecting such deposits. MSS issuance is a way out which can be used to support the fiscal deficit thus obviating the need for fresh borrowing. OMOs are also

likely where RBI sells its holding of government paper. The last is VRRR on a rolling basis — which will be an inferior solution for banks as the returns are the lowest.

Curiously, markets have been quite unmoved with the bond yields remaining where they are with expectations of a rate hike in future. The rupee has strengthened now, more out of sentiment. The dollars garnered will not directly affect the market as long as they are used to build reserves. If they are sold in the market, then it will help to strengthen the rupee.

The scheme raises some interesting ideas for further discussion. First, should the FCNR scheme be used periodically whenever it is felt that there is some slippage in the forex reserves? Based on the way in which the scheme was started and terminated early due to its success, a target sum can be announced such that the swap cost taken on by the RBI is, say, \$50 billion. Once this level is reached, the scheme can be stopped. The RBI can ask other central banks to invest in bonds issued by Indian banks in dollars, guaranteed by RBI, with a higher return than offered by the Fed. The protocol can be akin to FCNR, with similar spin-offs.

The writer is Chief Economist, Bank of Baroda. Views are personal

BELOW THE LINE



TVK MLA I Thahira B JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Mistaken identity
A non-existent tyre company created a big debate both inside and outside the Tamil Nadu Assembly. Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) Ranipet MLA I. Thahira in the Assembly raised a serious demand to shut down a JK Tyre manufacturing unit in her constituency over allegations of pollution. It emerged that the company has no such factory at Ranipet, and the MLA was referring to a local tyre retreading or melting unit. While the Industries Minister intervened, Opposition members poked fun over the allegations of a non-existent company in the region. JK Tyres even issued a statement stating it does not have a plant at Ranipet but has one in Sriperumbudur.

Playing favourites
US Ambassador to India Sergio Gora appears to have developed quite a liking for two key members of the Union Cabinet — External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar and Commerce and Industry Minister

Piyush Goyal. Speaking at a recent event in New Delhi, Gora named the duo as his 'favourite ministers'. Turning to Goyal, whom he called a 'dear friend', the envoy quipped, "If you can't get hold of me, reach out to Piyush and he'll arrange it". Goyal, however, was quick to point out the potential hazard of such high-level praise. "I'm worried about calling you a friend," the Minister remarked in a lighter vein. "If you make such comments, I'll have half of these people at my office looking for US visa appointments," drawing laughter from the audience. The banter is especially interesting given the ongoing delays in US visa processing. With the State Department recently adjusting

appointment schedules globally for consular officer training, applicant backlogs have only grown. Whether Goyal was simply playing to the gallery or using humour to nudge the embassy on a pressing public grievance is open to interpretation. **Turbulence or accident?** What began as a report on a turbulence encounter has acquired a new dimension, with the preliminary investigation into Air India flight AI2379 recording that neither the flight crew nor the air traffic control reported adverse weather during the altitude upset. The Airbus A320-251N was flying from Phuket to Delhi on August 4 with 145 people onboard. The occurrence was initially notified to the Aircraft Accident Investigation

Bureau (AAIB) by the Airports Authority of India as a turbulence encounter, with some people onboard sustaining injuries. However, after reaching the airport, collecting evidence, and assessing the injuries, the AAIB classified the occurrence as an accident and ordered an investigation to determine the probable causes and contributory factors. The report said the aircraft was cruising at FL360 in the Upper Bhubaneswar Sector. Weather forecasts indicated scattered and broken clouds, with temporary forecasts of light thunderstorms and rain later. However, no adverse weather was reported by the crew or ATC. **Our Bureaus**

ON THE CAMPAIGN
TRAIL.

Socially relevant campaigns caught the eye in the fortnight gone by, as did a very cool ‘moment marketing’ campaign from a brand that endearingly laughed at itself

Tough conversations

To mark World Alzheimer’s month, the Tata Trusts has launched ‘Vajood Rahe Maujood’, a new campaign on dementia awareness that seeks to shift the conversation around the condition from memory loss to the gradual loss of identity. Based on insights from people living with early-stage dementia, caregivers and medical experts, the campaign highlights how dementia can progressively affect the roles, relationships and everyday abilities that shape a person’s sense of self. Through an evocative film, the campaign aims to help families recognise early changes, start conversations sooner and take steps to preserve the identity of their loved ones for as long as possible. The film brings together actor Geeta Agarwal Sharma of *Laapataa Ladies* and *12th Fail* fame, who plays a mother showing early signs of dementia, and Priyanshu Painyuli (who played Robin in the web series *Mirzapur*) essaying the role of her son. The choice of a female protagonist reflects the disproportionate impact of dementia on women.

Easy grow

Nurturing takes on a whole new dimension in gardening platform Ugao’s latest campaign, which uses humour to show how easy plant parenting can be. Built around Jackie Shroff’s legendary love for plants, the film ropes in the actor’s son, Tiger Shroff, who shares how tough it was to get his dad’s attention. As Tiger looks back at his childhood, his backflips, bodybuilding and quirky personality are hilariously attributed to his attempts to compete with his father’s plant babies for the spotlight. It is a playful way to weave in Ugao USP — that plant parenting doesn’t have to demand so much from you. The film was conceptualised and produced by Kulfi Collective, with White Rivers Media as digital media partner.

Baseline shift

A pronunciation mistake became an occasion for a clever ‘moment marketing’ campaign. It all began when South Korean beauty creator Min Day Lee posted a video showing off her massive collection of Vaseline products, repeatedly mispronouncing the brand name as “Baseline” due to the lack of a “v” sound in Korean phonetics. People cracked jokes and shared the video, but Vaseline decided to join the fun, executing a brilliant real-time moment marketing campaign by temporarily rebranding its social media channels to “Baseline”. It took the joke further by saying it was appointing Min Day Lee as the CEO of Baseline. The brand won over the internet.

NUGGET.

Building up the festive consumer consideration

Traditionally, brands plan campaigns around fixed festival dates. But is that approach correct? A new report says that festive consumer consideration in India can begin building up nearly eight weeks before the festive peak. Taboola’s performance advertising platform Realize’s festive playbook 2026, ‘Light the Right Moments’, offers a data-led view of how consumer decision-making evolves across India’s festival period. One of the playbook’s key findings is that there is no single festive decision window. The technology, automotive, home, finance, fashion, jewellery and travel segments each follow different patterns of consumer consideration across the festival season. While some categories see interest building up earlier and remain active over an extended period, others are more closely linked to specific festive occasions or shorter periods of heightened intent. AI is also reshaping the journey, making it significantly faster for consumers to move from search to a shortlist. But the playbook finds that building confidence still takes time. Consumers continue to validate important decisions through multiple sources, including reviews, comparisons, expert perspectives, brand content, retailers and trusted publishers. The path from discovering an option to feeling confident enough to choose it, therefore, remains an active process of research and validation across the open internet. For brands, the task is to identify when consideration begins within their own category and build relevance from that point, rather than waiting for the festive peak to show up.

SHOCK TACTICS

When provocation becomes the product

IS RISQUE RISKY? From liquor counters to Instagram checkouts, brands are packing titillation into products and the buying experience

Amit Vijay Mohile

It was around 8.30 pm when Rahul Chhibber, a 32-year-old consultant, stopped at a South Delhi *theka* and told the salesman, “*Chaar BroCode dena. Full maza hai isme.*” The salesman handed over the four bottles of IndoBevs’ 15 per cent ABV (alcohol by volume) carbonated wine that Chhibber wanted, and threw in the company’s latest brand extension, BroTection — a packet of condoms. “*Extra maza ke liye,*” he said with a wink. BroCode, BroTection. The transaction itself had become the advertisement. From liquor counters to Instagram checkouts, brands are turning risqué positioning into products, purchase occasions and transactions across consumer categories worth an estimated ₹40,000 crore. “We are moving from risqué communication to risqué brand architecture,” says brand strategy specialist Harish Bijoor. “Earlier, the provocation typically sat in the advertising. What brands are experimenting with now is putting it into the product, the occasion and even the transaction.” Men’s innerwear is making a similar turn. Lux Cozi, VIP, Rupa Frontline and Amul Macho built mass recall around masculinity, humour and innuendo, most memorably Macho’s “*Yeh toh bada toing hai*”. Now D2C brand UNDRRESS is pitching ₹799–1,399 intimatewear around the female gaze, dates and intimacy. Instead of selling underwear primarily as an everyday necessity, UNDRRESS is associating it with occasions where consumers consciously want to look and feel desirable — a first date, Gen Z hook-up, Valentine’s Day, honeymoon or



PLEASURE PRINCIPLE. Desire as unique selling proposition



weekend away with a partner. Desire becomes a reason to trade up. “The Risqué 2.0 playbook is a brilliantly pragmatic strategy,” says Prathap Suthan, Chief Creative Officer at Bang In The Middle. “What we are seeing is the weaponisation of the transaction.” Brands, he says, are moving provocation “into products, retail and checkout”. COMMERCIAL CANVAS The sexual wellness and condoms market is estimated at ₹12,300 crore annually; men’s intimatewear at ₹18,000–22,000 crore; male grooming and deodorants at ₹5,500–6,500 crore; and ready-to-drink alcobevs at ₹2,500–3,200 crore — cumulatively ₹38,300–44,000 crore, according to industry estimates. RTD alcobevs demand is estimated to be growing 18–22 per cent annually, men’s intimatewear 11.5–

13 per cent, male grooming 8.5–10 per cent and sexual wellness 6–11 per cent. BroCode clocks ₹200–250 crore annual retail sales, while IndoBevs targets more than ₹700 crore in branded alcobev revenue in FY27. Risqué marketing isn’t new. Benetton used visual shock, FCUK sexual wordplay and Calvin Klein sensuality; in India, Tuff Shoes’ campaign featuring Milind Soman and Madhu Sapre in the buff courted controversy, while MR Coffee promised that “Real pleasure doesn’t come in an instant”. “Risqué advertising has been used globally for brands ranging from apparel, fashion and alcohol to even ice cream,” says advertising veteran Ambi Parameswaran. “In India, we are still using this form of advertising to sell undergarments and alcohol, after the misstep of Tuff Shoes.”



Sameer Mahandru, Founder, IndoBevs

“What we are seeing now is a doubling down by the same categories on their own version of risqué advertising, now with products to taunt consumers with,” he added. This marks the divide between the two playbooks. Risqué 1.0 largely used provocation to win attention and recall. Risqué 2.0 carries it into commerce: BroCode takes it to the liquor counter, BroTection into sexual wellness and UNDRRESS into premium intimatewear. BroTection’s collaboration with sexual-wellness brand Bold Care makes the crossover explicit with the tagline “Have Fun. Not Kids”. “We are done hiding behind soda,” says IndoBevs founder Sameer Mahandru. “If we are going to do surrogate advertising, it will reflect the reality of our consumers’ lives, not a sanitised version of it.” DIGITAL MAKES IT EASY Risqué 2.0 also has something its predecessors did not: Digital infrastructure capable of turning provocation into a transaction almost instantly. A Gen Z hook-up, honeymoon, Valentine’s date, house party or weekend away can begin with

Streaming six-yard sales through YouTube Live

Shakthi H

What does an IT career have to do with a saree business? For Chennai-based Ramya Devanathan, quite a lot. After 18 years at Tata Consultancy Services, she turned an attire that has been a part of her life since her teenage years into a business. The Covid-19 pandemic, which pushed consumers to buy everything — from groceries to medicines — online, gave her an opportunity. Devanathan decided to take the saree online too, via Madras Sarees — choosing a D2C model instead of investing in physical retail, and paying homage to her city through the brand name. Festivals and occasions have long driven saree purchases, but Devanathan saw few options for affordable sarees meant for work and everyday wear. That was the space Madras Sarees chose to explore, retailing cotton and silk sarees. There

are linen-cotton sarees at ₹999, aimed at those who wear sarees regularly to work. But a saree is not a simple product to sell. Devanathan points to the variables involved — fabric, weave, construction, regional identity, colour, drape and price. The way a saree is made can also vary, from handloom and powerloom weaving to techniques such as jacquard and printing. That breadth makes it challenging to position the category, says Jermina Menon, Brand and Marketing Strategist at Bhartiya Urban. Handloom, she notes, is a “beautiful” word, but can make a saree more expensive. A brand, therefore, needs to be clear about the customer and price point it is addressing, she says. The challenge becomes more pronounced online, as consumers cannot touch or feel the fabric. Madras Sarees uses YouTube Live commerce to take customers through details such as the saree’s fabric, construction, regional identity and authenticity, says Devanathan. The format also allows them to view the flow and weave of the saree,



IN A D2C DRAPE. Madras Sarees founder Ramya Devanathan



while covering measurements, wash care and styling details. She recalls a doctor who had to suddenly rush to surgery when she was watching a live session and had spotted a saree colour she liked. Unable to make the payment immediately, she sent a WhatsApp message asking the team to block the saree until she could return to complete the purchase. Getting a customer to make the first purchase is only part of the equation. Menon says a brand should also

give customers a reason to come back. Performance marketing can help generate the initial sale, she says, but the product must do the talking after that. Madras Sarees is also looking beyond conventional retail touchpoints. Devanathan says a saree kiosk has been set up in the city’s Abhiramapuram area, with the broader idea of locating such outlets in spaces where consumers are usually waiting for some other service — such as a

salon, where a client waiting for a hairstylist’s appointment, or an electric vehicle recharge point, where a customer charging her car can browse the sarees, place an order and have it delivered to a destination. The idea, she says, is to create an alternative point of brand visibility and sales. What began as a D2C approach to selling sarees now raises a larger question: How and where do consumers discover them? Devanathan’s vision is to become a trusted pan-Indian saree brand that is proudly rooted in Madras. But would the name Madras Sarees limit its reach by giving a wrong impression that it retails only South Indian weaves? “The name Madras Sarees is our foundation, not our boundary,” she says, pointing to several global brands named after cities or regions. “While we deeply celebrate south Indian weaves, we also curate beautiful sarees from across India. Madras Sarees uses the city as a brand anchor, not a geographic restriction,” she concludes.

Why does India’s food safety system need a Clint Eastwood?

There is a simple digital way to fix it by publishing violation information automatically, online, and not locking it in a database

DIGITAL
GADFLY



SHUBHO SENGUPTA

Between May and July this year, Tukaram Mundhe, a 2005 batch IAS officer from Beed, Maharashtra, reportedly walked into 3,137 restaurants, issued 764 improvement notices, and shut down 165 of the eateries. And became a *Singham*-style folk hero in the process, celebrated on social media and news channels as the bureaucrat who finally did what the system was supposed to do all along. The thing is, Maharashtra’s Food and Drug Administration has FoSCoS — the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India’s integrated digital platform — which is supposed to track licensing, inspections, lab results and penalties, with the whole chain digitised and connected. So you don’t really need a vigilante — it should be quiet, boring, predictable and effective work. There’s information, but no en-

forcement, not until Mundhe shows up. In theory, FoSCoS is elegant. Violation found → lab test ordered → results analysed → audit conducted → adjudication → penalty issued → restaurant closed. Clean. Logical. The system has too many blockers and not enough doers, however. Violations sit in audit, then in adjudication, then in enforcement — with each step a checkpoint that can delay matters indefinitely. HOW OTHERS FIXED THIS Singapore has inspections and rules just like we do, but here’s the critical difference: When a restaurant fails inspection, the rating gets published right there on the storefront, online, everywhere customers see it. The owner doesn’t fear the inspector or worry about fines — he fears customers who see “Failed” and go somewhere else instead. Revenue drops the same week, the owner fixes the problem immediately, and market pressure does what bureaucracy never could. In Denmark and Australia, violations go public within days, the media picks it up... And if one dis-



CALLING OUT. Making it easy for consumers to report food safety issues



trict is lenient, the neighbouring district looks clean by comparison, so officials can’t hide. WHAT INDIA SHOULDN’T DO India needs to stop building systems for bureaucrats and start building systems for customers. Publication of violation data should be automatic — not locked in a database, but online within 48 hours, in food delivery apps, on restaurant windows, so customers know before they eat. Celebrating Mundhe is basically admitting the system doesn’t work. A folk hero in regulatory en-

forcement is like a folk hero in water supply — it means something fundamental is broken. Singapore doesn’t have headlines about its food safety commissioner, neither does Denmark, or Australia, because when a system works, it’s invisible. So the question isn’t where to find the next Mundhe but how to build a system that doesn’t need him. MANY MUNDHES... Also, I realised while I was writing this — the ‘Mundhe principle’ is portable. Let’s take a quick look at some

other industries and categories. Real estate: Buyers have no idea if a building was flagged for structural issues. But if property listings showed municipal violation history, demand drops for sketchy buildings and developers would rush to fix. TV channels: There’s official data on complaints against news channels for promoting fake news, hate speech, bias and so on. But if that data appeared where you were choosing what to watch... Schools: Education Department inspects and finds violations, but parents don’t see it. Imagine school violation data published where you’re comparing institutions — suddenly, principals would move faster. Hospitals: There is data on doctor complaints, disciplinary actions, malpractice cases. Patients don’t see any of it. You pick a doctor on reputation or luck. But if that data appeared in the public domain... The lesson isn’t that India needs more heroes. It’s that India needs to stop hoarding regulatory data. Shubho Sengupta is a digital marketer with an analogue past

● ‘IN-BETWEEN’ STATE



A discovery that can help ease drug delivery

Team Quantum

Scientists at the Raman Research Institute (RRI) have found a way to make tightly jammed materials briefly behave like liquids — by giving them a sudden temperature shock.

The discovery could have implications in areas such as drug delivery, where scientists need to control when and how a material changes its structure and releases its contents.

Some materials lie between solid and liquid states. Glass is a familiar example. It behaves like a solid — you can hold it, cut it and break it — but the arrangement of its particles is disordered, more like in a liquid.

Such materials can also retain a kind of “memory” of the changes they undergo. The path they take while being heated or cooled can affect their final structure and behaviour.

Scientists are interested in finding ways of erasing this memory and temporarily making such jammed systems flow, because that would give them greater control over the material. The RRI researchers explored one such method using tiny, soft particles known as microgels.

Sonali Kawale, the first author of the study and a PhD student at RRI, packed these squishy particles tightly together so they could barely move. The result was a jammed system resembling glass, with particles locked in a disordered arrangement. Microgels can absorb 300-500 times their weight in water and are used in products such as diapers and sanitary napkins.

“Squeezing is never a good thing,” said Ranjini Bandyopadhyay, a co-author of the study, published in the *Journal of Colloid and Interface Science*. “In an ideal environment, these particles would like to move around. But they can’t. So they’re unhappy. If the whole thing starts flowing, that’s a happy situation.”

The researchers found a way of making the particles a little happier, at least temporarily.

They prepared a suspension of the microgel particles in water and studied what happened when its temperature was changed. They found that the route followed by the system while heating to a particular temperature was different from the route it followed while cooling to the original temperature.

In other words, the system remembered where it had come from.

But then the researchers changed the rules. By suddenly increasing the rate at which the temperature was changed — effectively giving the material a thermal shock — they triggered a rearrangement of the tightly packed particles.

The jammed system temporarily became more liquid-like.

More importantly, this rearrangement wiped out much of the system’s memory of its earlier heating and cooling history. Scientists had previously observed such path-dependent behaviour, but the RRI team’s work shows that it can potentially be controlled.

In drug delivery, at lower temperatures, the microgel particles can swell up like balls of jelly and absorb a drug. When heated above a certain temperature — around 34 degrees C in the system studied — they collapse and squeeze out their contents.

Such behaviour could potentially be used to release a medicine at a targeted location, such as a tumour, reducing unwanted effects elsewhere in the body.

● HEAT DETECTOR

A crystal that defies thermoelectric rules

STATE OF SURPRISE. How researchers stumbled upon quantum-grade sensing in an ordinary-looking, thin semiconductor film

M Ramesh

Just as we move away from a hot place to a comfortably cool one, so do charge carriers (electrons and holes) in atoms. If you heat one end of a metal bar, the carriers migrate towards the cooler end. As some charged particles migrate, there develops a pushback against the migration, leaving the two ends with a difference in electrical charge — one end positive, the other negative. When this happens, you have a voltage.

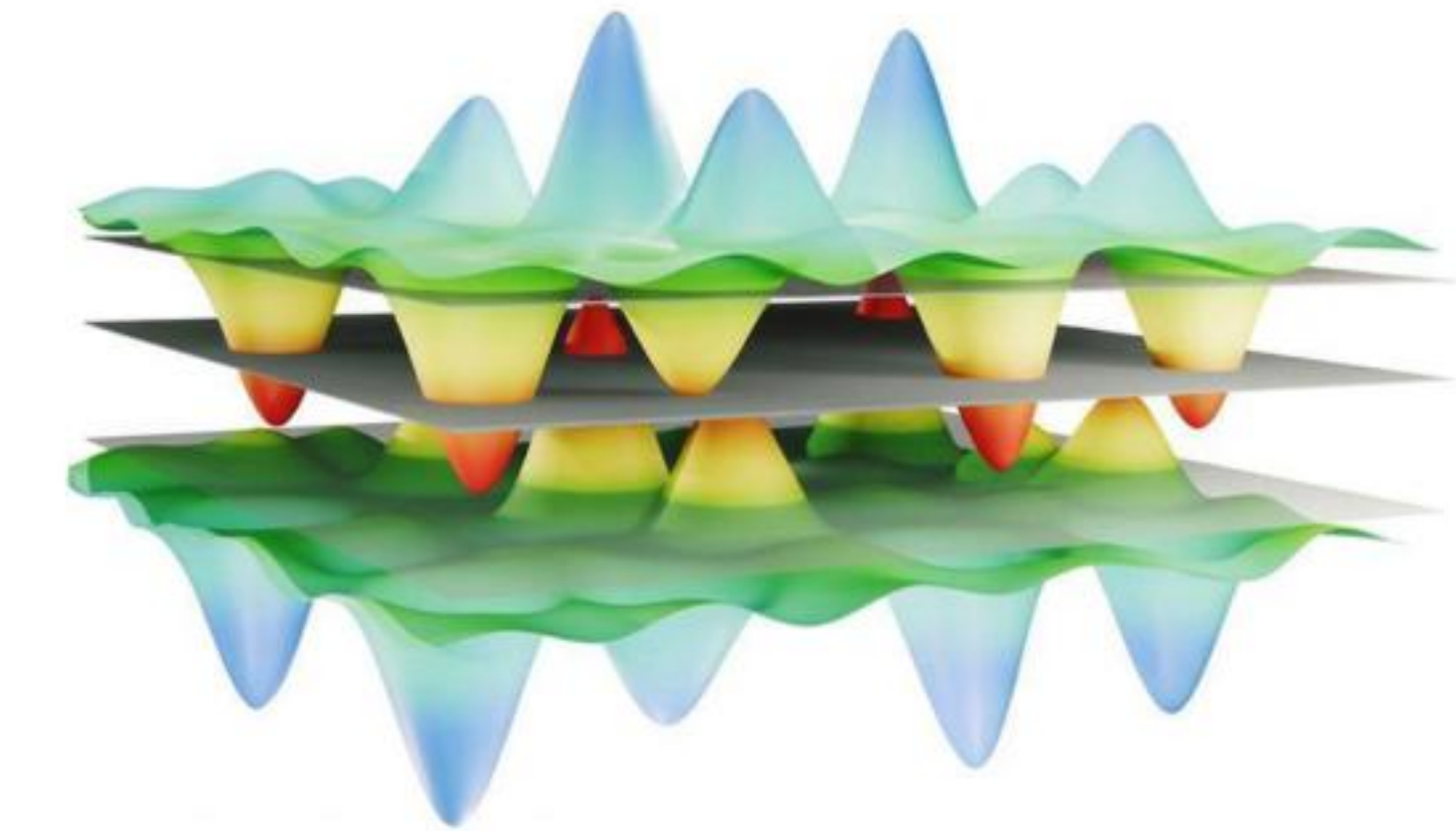
This was discovered in 1821 by Thomas Johann Seebeck, a German physicist of Baltic extraction. Seebeck was experimenting with circuits made of different metals when he noticed that a temperature difference could produce a magnetic effect near a compass needle — an observation that was later understood to arise from an electric current generated by heat.

He established, for the first time, a direct link between heat and electricity and laid the foundation for the science of thermoelectricity. Since then, the ‘Seebeck effect’ has been taught in high school physics textbooks.

Most metals produce Seebeck coefficients of only a few tens of microvolts per kelvin. Even good semiconductors typically manage a few hundred microvolts per kelvin. A few millivolts per kelvin was generally considered the upper end for crystalline solids.

Much larger values were the preserve of liquids and soft materials such as electrolytes, ionic gels and hydrogels, where ions rather than electrons move under a temperature gradient.

Now, a team led by Prof Bivas Saha of the Jawaharlal Nehru Centre for Advanced Scientific Re-



A schematic electronic band diagram of heavily doped, highly compensated scandium nitride IMAGE COURTESY JNCASR

search (JNCASR), working with researchers from the University of Sydney and the Indian Institute of Science (IISc), has reported a Seebeck coefficient exceeding –124.6 millivolts per kelvin near room temperature in a thin film of scandium nitride, which is of industrial significance.

That is several hundred times larger than the values normally associated with inorganic semiconductors, and nearly a hundred times beyond the previously accepted ceiling for crystalline solids.

The findings, published in *Science*, amount to something of a thermoelectric surprise: A solid crystal behaving, in one important respect, more like an electrolyte.

CAREFULLY ENGINEERED

The hero material — scandium nitride, or ScN — is a refractory transition-metal nitride. The researchers grew films of it on magnesium oxide substrates using ultra-high vacuum magnetron sputtering. Then came the crucial intervention.

ScN naturally contains free electrons, partly because of oxy-

gen impurities. The scientists deliberately introduced magnesium atoms, which compensated for these electrons. The result was what scientists call a heavily doped, highly compensated semiconductor.

In such a material, positive and negative dopant atoms are present in nearly equal numbers and are randomly distributed through the crystal. “We were not looking for a record-breaking number,” Prof Saha said. “We were trying to understand how disorder and charge compensation reshape electronic transport in scandium nitride.”

There was another surprise. The effect became stronger as the films were made thinner. The researchers have already taken the first step towards developing a device based on the phenomenon.

They fabricated a prototype photon sensor using a thin film of the highly compensated ScN, with two chromium contacts. A laser was shone on one of the contacts, heating it slightly and creating a tiny local temperature difference across the device. That small difference generated a measurable voltage corresponding to a See-

beck response of –102.4 millivolts per kelvin. The response was fast and repeatable, and the material showed no apparent degradation after repeated cycles.

INDUSTRIAL SIGNIFICANCE

The immediate implication is for extremely sensitive temperature and heat detectors. A material that produces a large voltage in response to a minute temperature difference can potentially detect very small thermal disturbances without requiring complicated amplification. That could be valuable in thermal imaging, heat-flux measurement and bolometers — devices that detect radiation by measuring the heating it produces. It could also matter for the rapidly growing internet-of-things universe, where billions of small sensors need to become cheaper, more sensitive and less power-hungry.

Perhaps the most intriguing possibilities lie in quantum technologies. The researchers believe that with further optimisation, such devices could potentially approach single-photon detection near room temperature.

At present, detecting individual photons often requires extremely sophisticated detectors and, in many cases, cryogenic cooling. The ScN discovery, therefore, points towards a tantalising possibility: Quantum-grade sensing based on an unusual form of thermoelectric amplification in an ordinary-looking semiconductor thin film. That possibility also resonates with India’s National Quantum Mission, which is seeking to build capabilities not only in quantum computing, but also quantum sensing and metrology.

At a recent National Conference on Quantum Biotechnology at IIT-Bombay, scientists, clinicians, start-ups and industry rep-

resentatives discussed how advances in quantum sensing could be translated into diagnostics, biomedical imaging, drug discovery and precision medicine.

SENSING ADVANCES

The underlying message is that the next quantum revolution may not depend only on building bigger quantum computers. It may also come from building instruments that can detect things that existing instruments simply cannot fathom. Prof Kasturi Saha, Project Director of QMet Tech Foundation at IIT-Bombay, captured the challenge neatly: Quantum biotechnology is where advances in sensing meet real clinical needs.

The scandium nitride discovery is not yet a commercial technology, and considerable work will be needed to understand the physics, optimise the material and manufacture reliable devices. But its industrial significance lies precisely in the fact that it opens a new materials design strategy.

For decades, engineers seeking superior thermoelectric materials largely tried to improve an existing balancing act between electrical conductivity, heat conductivity and thermopower. This work suggests another route: Engineer the right kind of disorder and charge compensation without sacrificing crystalline quality.

If that strategy can be reproduced in other materials and translated into scalable devices, it could lead to a new class of ultra-sensitive thermal and photon sensors — and perhaps give India’s quantum technology programme a promising materials platform of its own.

We value your feedback. Do send your comments to quantum@thehindu.co.in

● **WOW.** The magnetic lie detector



M Ramesh

When Thomas Hoving stood before a 2,000-year-old marble kouroi — statue of a nude Greek male — one word flashed in his mind: Fresh.

The J Paul Getty Museum in California had tested the kouroi against fakery — the kouroi had passed the test. The thin layer of calcite stamped it right — after all, it takes thousands of years for dolomite marble to turn into calcite.

Yet Hoving, a former Director of the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York, thought ‘fresh’.

Opening his book, *Blink*, Malcom Gladwell describes how it took teams of experts to

determine that the kouroi was fake, while Hoving and a few others spotted it right away, intuitively.

Suppose you are an ancient-pottery forger. You have done a magnificent job. The clay is right. The shape is perfect. You have even given it a suitably battered appearance.

There is just one problem. The earth remembers. When clay is fired in a kiln and cools, tiny magnetic minerals inside it line themselves up with the earth’s magnetic field, rather like microscopic compass needles. The resulting magnetic signature gets locked into the pottery. This is called thermal remanent magnetisation, or TRM.

Now, here is the catch for our unfortunate forger: Earth’s magnetic field does not stay put. Magnetic North wanders over time. So, a pot fired 2,000 years ago carries a subtly different magnetic signature from one made yesterday.

But there is more. Over centuries, ancient pottery slowly picks up a second, much weaker magnetic signal from the earth’s changing magnetic field. Scientists call this viscous remanent magnetisation, or VRM. For more than a century, researchers have largely regarded it as a nuisance — noise interfering with the stronger original signal.

The idea is deliciously simple: An ancient object has had centuries to acquire this secondary magnetic memory; a modern forgery has not. While this technique cannot tell you if the pot was made in 321 BC or 431 BC, it can assure you that it was not made last month.

Now, how did the kouroi forger get the calcite layer? Well, turns out that you can ‘age’ dolomite marble using potato mold.

But that was in the early 1980s. Today, dear forger, things are different.

● **AUTOMATING MARKETS**

Machine learning to trade

N Nagaraj

In 1962, an economist named Vernon Smith ran an experiment with students at Purdue. Half got a slip with a secret number: The most they could pay for a pretend good. The other half got a different secret number: The least they’d accept to sell it. Nobody saw anyone else’s slip, and an auctioneer at the front simply called out and recorded each bid and ask, declaring a trade whenever one met the other. There was, unknown to any of them, a single price — the point economists call the ‘equilibrium’ — at which the gains available from the whole market were as large as possible.

Yet, round after round of calling out numbers and haggling, strangers with no shared information beyond overheard bids and asks had pushed prices strikingly close to it, as though the room had solved a puzzle none of them could individually see. This is the double auction, the mechanism underlying most centralised financial and commodity markets. Smith would go on to share the 2002 Nobel Prize in Economic Sciences for establishing laboratory experiments as a tool of economic analysis.

Large language models now take on the roles once played by Smith’s students, negotiating and trading on people’s behalf. A team of four researchers tested whether AI agents reproduce Smith’s result in their recent study, titled *Competitive market behaviour of LLMs*.

They built a Smith-style double auction adapted for AI agents: 11 buyers, 11 sellers, each with a private reservation price, trading through an order book that accepted only improving quotes. Every trader was an AI agent — drawn from a large OpenAI model; a smaller and cheaper sibling of the same family; and a large Google model — each run 10 times over.

None of the three converged fully to the competitive equilibrium. Prices stayed well above what Smith’s humans had managed, and trading volume often fell short of the six trades the equilibrium implied. This wasn’t a failure of arith-



metic; each agent was explicitly told to maximise profit and was given its own reservation price. The failure sat somewhere between understanding a market and knowing how to behave inside one. It was not the flagship model that came closest to functioning as a market. The larger, more capable OpenAI model produced the worst market of the three. Its agents kept improving their quotes in one cent increments and simply refused to close the gap, so trading volume fell to between a third and two-thirds of the equilibrium quantity — rent-seeking taken to a self-defeating extreme.

The smaller, cheaper sibling behaved rather better. Its buyers and sellers leapt across meaningful price gaps rather than inching toward them and, round over round, its markets tightened in the same broad pattern Smith’s humans had shown, with efficiency climbing above 90 per cent by the final round. It behaved as though it were, in some rough sense, adapting to the structure of the game. The researchers are careful not to oversell this, since their design wasn’t meant to isolate the effect of model size, but it echoes other research suggesting that greater sophistication doesn’t necessarily make AI traders more human-like.

One model provides reasoning traces as it trades, and combing through them shows a pattern: While an agent shaved cents off its offer, its language was dominated by words like ‘strategic’ and ‘optimise’ — the vocabulary of protecting a margin. The moment it leapt across the spread to trade, that vocabulary shifted toward ‘immediate’, ‘secure’, ‘guarantee’ — the vocabulary of urgency. The researchers caution that the stated reasoning need not match the

computation actually driving it, but the shift suggests two instincts in tension: One protecting profit, and one eventually panicking about ending the round with nothing sold.

AI agents are already being used for pricing, negotiation, bidding and financial tasks. The mechanisms within which they operate were built around assumptions about how human traders behave, and a mechanism that reliably squeezes efficiency out of self-interested humans may need different rules, or a human hand at the wheel, when the traders are language models instead.

The same caution applies to research using language models as stand-ins for human subjects: Smith’s result is one of the most robust findings in experimental economics, and even here the language models didn’t reproduce it off the shelf.

There’s a narrower implication, too. Some researchers read the repeated small price adjustments by AI agents as evidence of collusion. But calling a price “collusive” only makes sense against a baseline of what honest, non-colluding agents would produce, and the obvious baseline is the competitive equilibrium. If AI agents on their own can’t reliably find that equilibrium in the first place, a price sitting above it isn’t necessarily proof of a conspiracy.

Whether AI agents can ever be trusted inside markets built for humans remains open. The institution that let a room of anonymous 1962 undergraduates turn scattered private information into a remarkably accurate public price does not, on the evidence here, produce the same result with machines. At least not yet, and not without knowing rather more about which machines, and why.

India brings a small machine to the fusion race

The country deploys its first spherical tokamak to see if it can produce high-pressure, stable plasma

Venkatachari Jagannathan

The Institute for Plasma Research (IPR) in Gujarat has commissioned India’s first spherical tokamak and begun plasma experiments, marking the country’s entry into a specialised area of fusion research.

Behind the compact machine lies a big question: Can scientists learn to control on the same process that powers the sun, and eventually use it to generate electricity?

A tokamak uses powerful magnetic fields to hold an extremely hot gas called plasma. Under extreme conditions, atoms can fuse together and release enormous amounts of energy. This process, nuclear fusion, is what powers the sun.

Conventional tokamaks are broadly doughnut-shaped. A spherical tokamak is more compact and resembles a hollowed-out apple. Scientists are studying whether this configuration can produce high-pressure plasma in a smaller machine.

The first plasma was produced on December 11, 2025, and scientists have since carried out 114 plasma discharges. They, however, found that when the magnetic system is switched on, large unwanted electrical currents are induced in the metal walls of the vessel.

These currents, in turn, produce magnetic effects that interfere with the plasma. The researchers are exploring ways to compensate for the unwanted current by changing the arrangement of the magnetic coils or using additional sources.

The vacuum inside the machine has improved substantially through regular glow-discharge cleaning, to remove gases and impurities from the vessel walls. Further wall-conditioning methods are being optimised. For the IPR, beyond producing plasma the challenge is to make it last longer and remain stable.

GLOBAL EFFORT

India is not alone in pursuing spherical tokamak technology. The UK has the Mega Ampere Spherical



SUN ON EARTH. Bright plasma glows inside the reactor vessel of the Mega Ampere Spherical Tokamak in Culham, UK

Tokamak Upgrade (MAST-U), while private company Tokamak Energy is developing the ST40 spherical tokamak. Britain is also working on the Spherical Tokamak for Energy Production (STEP), a prototype fusion power plant.

The US has the National Spherical Torus Experiment Upgrade (NSTX-U) at the Princeton Plasma Physics Laboratory.

Japan has the Q-shu University

Experiment with Steady-State Spherical Tokamak (QUEST).

China, South Korea, Russia, Italy and Spain also have spherical tokamak research programmes.

BENEFITS

Commercial fusion power is still some distance away. But the potential prize is enormous.

If successful, it could provide large quantities of low-carbon electricity. Unlike conventional nuclear fission, fusion does not depend on a chain reaction. If the conditions needed for fusion disappear, the reaction stops.

But fusion cannot yet be described as cheap electricity. Nobody knows what commercial fusion power will ultimately cost.

The significance of India’s spherical tokamak, therefore, lies not in the electricity it can produce today, but the knowledge and expertise it can build for the future.

The writer is an independent journalist based in Chennai

NAVI MUMBAI AIRPORT USHERS
IN GLOBAL CARGO GIANTS



The Navi Mumbai International Airport welcomed the Antonov An-124 ‘Ruslan’, one of the world’s largest production cargo aircraft and a Code F wide-bodied freighter. Designed to transport heavy and oversized cargo, the An-124 is distinguished by its unique front-loading capability, with its nose opening to facilitate the loading of large consignments. Arriving from Abu Dhabi with approximately 46 tonnes of cargo, the aircraft’s visit demonstrates the NMIA’s ability to accommodate large, specialised freighter aircraft and support complex cargo operations.

GLOBAL BYTES.

APM Terminals builds big in Bangladesh

APM Terminals marked the official groundbreaking for APM Terminals Laldia, in Chattogram, as one of the largest public-private partnership investments in Bangladesh’s history as it moves from the signing to the construction stage. The \$550-million project is the flagship outcome of a government-to-government partnership that Bangladesh forged with Denmark to modernise its critical trade infrastructure. APM Terminals Laldia will be fully designed, financed, built and operated by APM Terminals and its partners in a first-of-its-kind model for Bangladesh’s port sector. Crucially, the port asset remains with Bangladesh even as it reaps the benefits of world-class private investment and operational expertise.



Surge in global container fleet capacity

“When the world’s shipyards deliver just a few more container ships, the global fleet capacity will for the first time reach 34 million twenty-foot equivalent units (TEU). At that time, the fleet will have grown by 10 million TEU — or 42 per cent — in just five- and-a-half years,” says Niels Rasmussen, Chief Shipping Analyst, BIMCO. To compare, earlier it took more than ten- and-a-half years to add 10 million TEU to increase fleet capacity to 24 million TEU, said BIMCO. At the beginning of September, global container fleet capacity was just 8,000 TEU below the 34-million-TEU mark. The milestone will, therefore, be reached after only a few of the 46 ships (totalling 2,86,000 TEU), scheduled for September delivery, enter into service.



Demand grows for air cargo services

The International Air Transport Association’s data for July global air cargo markets shows that demand grew nearly 4 per cent year-on-year. While all regions recorded growth, airlines in the Asia-Pacific, Europe and North America accounted for more than 90 per cent of the increase. Dedicated freighters gained market share as belly-hold traffic declined, possibly reflecting demand for larger or specialist shipments and the operational flexibility freighters can provide. Looking ahead, the outlook remains broadly positive, supported by manufacturing activity, export orders and global trade. However, higher fuel prices, geopolitical tensions and tariff uncertainty need to be watched carefully, said Marie Owens Thomsen, IATA’s Senior Vice-President, Sustainability, and Chief Economist.



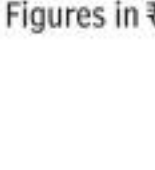
RE POSTS.

- ✕ International passengers can now present their e-boarding passes during immigration clearance. Effective 1 September 2026, physical stamping of boarding passes is no longer required as the process moves towards a digital and paperless experience.
Chennai (MAA) Airport
@aachinaairport
- ✕ Save 1033, the toll-free helpline on National Highways, for support during emergency and non-emergency situations. Whether it is a breakdown, accident, medical need or general assistance, one call connects you to immediate help. Keep 1033 handy and travel with greater confidence on every journey.
MORTHINDIA
@MORTHIndia

Truck rental rates

Rentals for 18-tonne payload

Truck route	Rentals as on		% change
	Aug 20	Sep 3	
Delhi-Mumbai-Delhi	1,76,000	1,75,000	-0.57
Delhi-Nagpur-Delhi	1,62,000	1,63,000	0.61
Delhi-Kolkata-Delhi	1,79,000	1,82,000	1.65
Delhi-Guwahati-Delhi	1,97,000	1,96,000	-0.51
Delhi-Hyderabad-Delhi	2,04,000	2,05,000	0.49
Delhi-Chennai-Delhi	2,20,000	2,20,000	0.00
Delhi-Bengaluru-Delhi	2,26,000	2,29,000	1.31
Delhi-Ranchi-Delhi	1,72,000	1,75,000	1.71
Delhi-Raipur-Delhi	1,68,000	1,68,000	0.00
Delhi-Kandla-Delhi	1,44,000	1,46,000	1.37
Mumbai-Chennai-Mumbai	1,75,000	1,75,000	0.00
Ludhiana-Hyderabad-Ludhiana	2,04,000	2,05,000	0.49
Mumbai-Kolkata-Mumbai	2,05,000	2,07,000	0.97
Chennai-Ahmedabad-Chennai	2,14,000	2,16,000	0.93
Bengaluru-Kolkata-Bengaluru	2,15,000	2,18,000	1.38
Bengaluru-Mumbai-Bengaluru	1,49,000	1,50,000	0.67
Delhi-Thiruvananthapuram-Delhi	2,85,000	2,88,000	1.04
Guwahati-Mumbai-Guwahati	2,85,000	2,87,000	0.70
Nagpur-Chennai-Nagpur	1,67,000	1,71,000	2.34
Kolkata-Guwahati-Kolkata	1,61,000	1,63,000	1.23
Indore-Delhi-Indore	1,48,000	1,52,000	2.63
Ahmedabad-Indore-Ahmedabad	1,05,000	1,05,000	0.00
Vijayawada-Mumbai-Vijayawada	1,65,000	1,68,000	1.79
Vijayawada-Kolkata-Vijayawada	1,56,000	1,57,000	0.64
Mumbai-Nagpur-Mumbai	1,17,000	1,20,000	2.50
Mumbai-Pune-Mumbai	72,000	75,000	4.00
Mumbai-Aurangabad-Mumbai	85,000	88,000	3.41
Mumbai-Nashik-Mumbai	70,000	74,000	5.41



Figures in ₹ Source: Subham Freight Carriers India Pvt Ltd

● PEAK FREIGHT

Logistics firms brace for festival runs

SEASON OF JOY. Delivery speed and scale are in focus as the festival shopping window stretches over several months

T E Raja Simhan

Beginning with Onam in August and up to Pongal in January, India’s festival calendar is turning into an extended peak season for the logistics industry, with the e-commerce, organised retail, consumer electronics, fashion and consumer durables segments expected to push cargo and express volumes higher.

What’s different this year is not merely the quantum of demand. Today’s customers increasingly expect deliveries marked by speed, flexibility and visibility, even as the festival shopping window stretches over several months and reaches deeper into tier-2 and tier-3 cities.

For logistics companies, this means shedding the traditional response of adding trucks, aircraft capacity, manpower and warehouses during peak season in favour of a more technology-driven model — one built around predicting emerging pressure points and moving capacity before bottlenecks develop. This includes distributed fulfilment, multimodal networks and flexible capacity.

The festival season is becoming a test of not just how much freight India’s logistics networks can carry, but also how intelligently they can respond to changing demand, say company officials.

A spokesperson of Flipkart said the e-commerce company’s supply chain and logistics subsidiary Ekart handles more than 3 billion packages annually, most of it related to festival season shopping, including its ‘Big Billion Days’ sales. As volumes scale up, Ekart’s infrastructure can handle up to 10 times the normal volume during peak periods.

In step with rising expectations, Flipkart offers same-day and next-day delivery in 250 cities, supported by Ekart’s nationwide logistics network. At the same time, the emergence of quick commerce is adding another layer to the festive rush, with nearly 1,050 micro-fulfilment centres across 130-plus cities active on its Minutes platform.

A LONGER, BROADER PEAK

Since the festival season runs from August to January, the cargo flow is more sustained rather than occurring in short, sharp spikes around individual shopping events.

Blue Dart expects to see increased movement of apparel and fashion accessories, consumer electronics and mo-



CELEBRATION TIME. Digital commerce has spread the express delivery demand beyond metros into tier-2 and -3 markets ISTOCK

bile devices, helped by festival sales promotions, product launches and growth in online shopping.

“We anticipate a healthy increase in cargo movement during the festive period, driven by sustained consumer demand and strong momentum across the e-commerce and retail sectors,” said Vikram Mansukhani, Chief of Operations, Blue Dart.

The delivery service company is also seeing demand from D2C brands and marketplaces that need agile logistics networks during seasonal peaks.

“Our focus during the festival season this year is on enhancing network agility, operational efficiency and customer experience. We continue to strengthen our forecasting and capacity planning capabilities through data-driven insights and predictive analytics, enabling us to respond more effectively to volume fluctuations. We are also augmenting processing capabilities at select locations and leveraging our integrated air and ground network to deliver greater speed and reliability,” Mansukhani said.

Vijay Kumar, CEO, Express Industry Council of India (EICI), said that while the festival season remains one of the busiest periods for the express delivery industry, digital commerce is expanding

beyond major metros into tier-2 and tier-3 markets, bringing more customers into the express delivery ecosystem.

BUILDING CAPACITY

Logistics companies began preparations months before the first major festival orders were placed.

Abhishek Chakraborty, CEO, DTDC Express Ltd, said the company expects substantially higher festival cargo movement this year, with Onam volumes already clocking nearly 30 per cent more than the monthly average. The impact was even greater in international deliveries, with revenue during the Onam month nearly twice the monthly average. “We expect demand to remain elevated during the festival cycle, until January,” he said.

The company has strengthened its network capacity by adding new facilities, transit hubs and processing infrastructure along key demand corridors. It is using data-led planning to deploy manpower, vehicles and processing capacity according to anticipated volumes, he said.

DTDC is also optimising movement along high-density corridors and using technology to improve shipment visibility and load planning. Its network of 16,500-plus customer access points, along with its hubs and branches,

provides the company with the scale and flexibility needed to respond as volumes build, he said.

One interesting initiative by DTDC is its Vallam Express in Kerala, which takes last-mile delivery onto waterways to reach communities that have limited road connectivity. The service is expected to facilitate more than 5,000 deliveries during the year, Chakraborty said.

FreightFox foresees about 40 per cent higher festival season demand compared with last year, according to Nitish Rai, Founder and CEO. “The festive season is typically the period when our business is busiest, with demand from the FMCG, retail and consumer durables sectors all rising together,” Rai said.

He added that some highway routes become congested much faster than others, and that problems could emerge on the quieter routes before becoming visible in broader network-level numbers. For logistics operators, identifying these pressure points early is becoming as important as forecasting the overall peak.

“The supply chain is, at present, not completely ready to meet this degree of demand,” Rai said, pointing to the need for improvements in visibility, planning, transporter networks and decision-making when routes become crowded.

● VERTICAL INTEGRATION

Regulating for infra equity



JAGANNARAYAN PADMANABHAN

There is a curious asymmetry in the way we regulate transport infrastructure.

In container shipping, it is increasingly common, and widely accepted, for an ocean carrier to own a stake in the terminal where its ships berth. MSC owns and operates terminals through Terminal Investment Limited (TIL); Maersk has APM Terminals; CMA CGM has built a substantial global terminal portfolio; and Hapag-Lloyd has established Hanseatic Global Terminals across various hub-and-spoke locations.

The situation is no different in India. Recent examples include Hapag-Lloyd acquiring 40 per cent stake in JM Baxi Ports & Logistics; CMA CGM in partnership in Nhava Sheva Free Port Terminal; and MSC’s Terminal Investment agreement to acquire 49 per cent stake in Vizhinjam terminal, operated by Adani Ports.

The logic is straightforward. A shipping line investing in a terminal can bring capital, technology, cargo and operational expertise. It can align vessel schedules with terminal operations, improve asset utilisation, create transshipment hubs and provide greater

certainty of capacity. However, there is a potential downside.

A carrier-controlled terminal could favour its own vessels, provide preferential berthing or pricing or disadvantage competing shipping lines. These concerns need to be addressed through concession conditions, competition law, transparent tariffs and non-discriminatory access requirements.

The recent debate over whether airport operators should be allowed to own airlines has brought into focus a much larger policy issue: How should India regulate vertical integration across the transport sector?

Concerns over airport ownership by airlines are understandable. Airports control scarce resources, such as slots, gates, parking stands and passenger facilities. An airport operator with interests in an airline could potentially favour it, disadvantaging competitors. Equally, a dominant airline controlling an airport could influence access to critical infrastructure.

This raises the question why such ownership structures, viewed as a potential problem in aviation, are accepted in maritime transport.

PROS AND CONS

The potential for conflicts of interest exists in ports too, yet vertical integration between shipping

lines and terminals is generally permitted. This warrants closer examination.

According to media reports, the Ministry of Civil Aviation has clarified that India does not have a blanket prohibition on airport operators owning or operating airlines. Restrictions largely arise from the concession agreements of individual public-private partnership airports. Notably, Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru and Hyderabad airports — which together account for nearly 80 per cent of India’s passenger traffic — contain such restrictions.

Vertical integration can generate significant benefits, including improved coordination across the value chain, economies of scale, growth in investment and operational efficiencies. At the same time, it can potentially lead to market foreclosure and concentration of market power.

Several developed economies follow vertical integration, where airlines operate dedicated terminals within airports, while competitive neutrality is maintained through regulatory oversight rather than outright ownership prohibitions.

In India, while policymakers aspire to create an integrated multimodal logistics system, regulation remains organised around individual modes.

As the country enters an era of unprecedented investment in transport and logistics infrastructure, questions remain over how vertical integration may improve efficiency and how it may harm competition. The apparent solution is to allow integration where it creates value, regulate where it creates market power, and ensure competition through transparent and consistent regulations.

After all, what’s good for the goose should not automatically be bad for the gander.

The writer is Senior Director and Global Head – Consulting, Crisil Ltd

We value your feedback. Do send your comments to bl.logistics@thehindu.co.in

● SOARING BEYOND HYDERABAD

Telangana eyes growth led by regional airports



WAITING FOR TAKE-OFF. Mamnoon in Warangal

G Naga Sridhar

Telangana’s aviation map appears set for a significant expansion, with Bhadradi Kothagudem, Warangal and Adilabad in focus for the State’s push to take air connectivity beyond capital Hyderabad.

For a largely land-locked State — with investment, employment and high-value economic activity traditionally concentrated in and around Hyderabad — the airport projects could provide the missing air link in developing stronger regional economic centres.

The State government has taken up the regional airports issue with Union Civil Aviation Minister K Rammo-han Naidu on several occasions, including during Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy’s recent visit to the Capital.

For the Bhadradi Kothagudem airport proposal, a Central technical team will arrive this month to inspect four or five shortlisted sites.

The Bhadradi Kothagudem region is home to the Sri Sitaramachandra Swamy temple, in Bhadrachalam, a major pilgrim destination, apart from its renown as an industrial and natural resources base.

In Warangal, the CM sought the Centre’s intervention for the early execution of the airport project at Mamnoon. With land acquisition completed, tenders are being floated, targeting project completion by the end of 2028.

Beyond just a regional airport, Mamnoon is being pitched for development according to international standards, with integrated facilities for maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO), air cargo and hangar services.

The historic town of Warangal is a trading hub for agribased and other industries, alongside a steadily developing services sector, including the Warangal IT Tower.

The proposed airport is expected to support the Kakatiya Mega Textile Park, Kazipet Coach Factory and other industrial activity, while serving as an important aviation gateway for northern Telangana.

“The proposed airport could, therefore, become part of a wider economic geography in which manufacturing, logistics and services need not necessarily gravitate towards Hyderabad simply because air connectivity is concentrated there,” a senior official of the Telangana Industries Department said.

At Adilabad, the CM requested the Defence Ministry to develop a civil airport alongside the proposed defence airport, and offered support for land acquisition.

MY FIVE.



Fitness ring, daily walk, and balance of food

- 1 Movement: It's non-negotiable. Daily walking has become an important part of my routine. I consciously build movement into my workday through small changes like taking meetings while walking, standing during calls and avoiding prolonged periods of sitting.
- 2 Balance: It's always balance over restriction. I enjoy burgers, pizza, chaat and samosas, but focus on moderation. I balance indulgences with protein, vegetables and fibre, rather than cutting out the foods I enjoy.
- 3 Commit: Walking has been a gamechanger for me. By improving my daily habits and consistently walking 20,000-30,000 steps a day, I lost significant weight in just 3-4 months. Milind Soman and his commitment to lifelong fitness have been an inspiration.
- 4 Fitness ring: I try to make health a measurable part of my routine. I use my fitness ring to track movement, stress and recovery, which helps me understand when I need to take a break or get back to my routine. It keeps me accountable, even during demanding periods.
- 5 Consistent: I aim for at least 20 km of movement every day and find ways to stay active throughout the day. This helps avoid binge-eating. It's less about intense workouts and more about keeping movement consistent.

CAPSULE.

WHO validates Bhutan's rabies-free status

Bhutan is the first country in Southeast Asia to be validated by the World Health Organization (WHO) for eliminating dog-transmitted rabies. Rabies is a viral disease that is almost always fatal once clinical symptoms appear. However, rabies deaths are preventable. Vaccinating dogs curbs the disease at its source, and the prompt use of post-exposure prophylaxis (PEP) stops the virus from reaching the central nervous system after a bite. PEP entails thorough wound washing, administration of a course of human rabies vaccine and, when indicated, rabies immunoglobulins (RIG) injection.

The WHO's goal is to end human deaths from dog-transmitted rabies by 2030, said Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, WHO Director-General, adding that Bhutan's success showed that the health of humans, animals and the environment was "inextricably" linked.

COMING UP.

Suicide prevention: Speak up

World Suicide Prevention Day (September 10) was established in 2003 by the International Association for Suicide Prevention, in partnership with the World Health Organization. 'Start the Conversation' is the call to action to mark the final year of the triennial (2024-26) theme 'Changing the Narrative on Suicide'. It calls on people to challenge harmful myths, reduce stigma and foster open, compassionate conversations about suicide. It also calls for prioritising suicide prevention and mental health in public policy.

● UNHEALTHY TREND

Patient safety in a time of fakes, misbrands and recalls

KEY ISSUES. Are fake drugs withdrawn on time, and is the regulatory system working as it should?

PT Jyothi Datta

August proved a troubling month for patient safety — with at least four separate reports related to fake medicines, voluntarily recalls and alleged misbranding.

An inter-State fake drugs network was busted after counterfeit blood pressure drug (Nicaardia Retard) was seized in Gujarat by the Ahmedabad Crime Branch and State Food and Drugs Administration (FDA). The fakes were reportedly flagged by JB Chemicals after products carrying its branding but not made by it were found in the market.

In the second instance, the Drug Controller General of India flagged a fake rabies vaccine batch carrying the same branding and batch number as an Indian Immunological's vaccine. A search at a Delhi residence by the Crime Branch and drug inspectors found "rabies vaccine (Abhayrab); Batch No. KE25012... misbranded (not manufactured by Indian Immunologicals Ltd)", said a public notice from the regulator.

The third report was on the voluntary withdrawal of 11 eye drops by Sun Pharma as a "precautionary" measure. And the fourth was about the cancellation of Cipla's Pune warehouse licence, and its subsequent restoration by the Maharashtra FDA following a court directive, after Cipla contested the cancellation. It involved an ongoing case over alleged misbranding of Reactin Plus tablets, the State FDA said.

The frequency of these alleged violations poses critical questions on patient safety: Are fake or ineffective medicines withdrawn from the market before they are consumed by patients? Does the drug regulatory framework need tightening or are more cases being reported due to improved regulatory intervention?



The Health Ministry, for example, regularly releases reports of 'not of standard quality' (NSQ) medicines and spurious drugs (imitation products that may or may not have the active ingredient). The spurious drug alert, though, does not name the company or brand, except to say it is being investigated.

HEALTH THREAT

The July NSQ/spurious drug report, for example, mentions spurious buprenorphine injection IP 2ml, a painkiller. In the Ahmedabad case involving fake blood pressure medicines, media reports said 1,500 strips (of 10 tablets each) may have been sold to patients.

Dr Abhay Shukla, National Convener of Jan Swasthya Abhiyan, explained that medicines are prescribed to treat a particular condition. So if a medicine is NSQ, it could be "health-threatening", if not life-threatening. An ineffective NSQ blood pressure medicine could lead to a stroke or heart attack, he pointed out.

Dr HG Koshia, former Commissioner of the Gujarat Food and Drugs Control Administration, recollected that when he took charge (2009-10), about 95 per cent of recalled drugs had

been consumed before the companies began recalling them. The State regulator then put in place an SMS-based recall system to alert the supply chain, distributor, wholesaler and retail chemist, said Koshia, who retired in 2025.

WHO IS RESPONSIBLE?

Company representatives sometimes claim that they have visibility only up to the distributor and not the neighbourhood chemist. That is not a legitimate reason, said Koshia, since manufacturing licences are for selling quality medicines, and the onus is on them to produce medicine that retains quality until expiry.

If there is a recall for some reason, the companies must ensure the products come back to them, he said, adding that distributors have the supply data for the medicines. The Drugs and Cosmetics (D&C) Act mandates a bill or memo for every product sold, mentioning the product name, batch number, the names of purchaser and wholesaler, the quantity sold and the expiry date. This has been "the law of the land since 1945", he said.

Former Commissioner of Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration Mahesh Zagade said the

regulatory framework for medicines is adequate.

It is the Health Secretaries and drug regulators who have to implement the food and drugs statutes and act against those failing to do their job, he said.

Zagade had, as FDA chief, called for compensation for patients when J&J recalled hip implants. On product recalls, he said there are provisions to detail the drug supply chain down to the consumer "but they are on paper". Almost 100 per cent of recalled products get consumed, he alleged, with the reasons ranging from delays in sample testing to corrupt "money-making".

FIXING ACCOUNTABILITY

Manufacturers are mandated to test raw materials before using them and the finished product before releasing it in the market, Zagade said, a process that can ensure only quality products are available.

Parliamentarians also need to ensure that laws they help formulate are implemented in their constituencies. Otherwise they should raise it with the Central and State governments, he said, adding that this culture of holding people accountable would help protect customer rights.

● FROM THE REGULATOR

Data sharing on animal testing alternatives

The European Medicines Agency (EMA) has launched a new voluntary data submission (VDS) pilot to facilitate the sharing of data generated using New Approach Methodologies (NAMs). These innovative methods have the potential to provide information comparable to, or better than current testing approaches, while helping replace or reduce the use of traditional animal studies in the non-clinical development of medicines.

This pilot is part of the EMA's efforts to foster the regulatory acceptance of NAMs by enabling regulators to gain experience with these approaches and assess their scientific value. NAMs can include complex in vitro systems, such as organoids and microphysiological systems, computational models and a combination of multiple methodologies. Ultimately, the initiative aims to strengthen the future use of scientifically robust alternatives to animal testing in regulatory decision-making. It builds on the EMA's longstanding commitment to the 3Rs principles — replace, reduce and refine the use of animals in medicine development and regulation.

Although NAMs are increasingly used in research and early medicine development, data on their use is rarely shared with regulators, limiting the opportunities to build confidence in their regulatory application.

The new VDS pilot aims to create a structured, non-binding framework that enables companies, method developers, contract research organisations, academic laboratories and other stakeholders to voluntarily submit and discuss NAM data independent of a marketing authorisation application. Participants will receive individual, non-binding and non-decisional feedback from an operational expert group, comprising non-clinical experts from across the European medicines regulatory network.

The initiative aims to enhance scientific dialogue, increase regulatory experience with NAMs, promote harmonised assessment approaches across Europe and support the development of a sustainable framework for integrating these innovative methods into medicine regulation.

Organisations interested in participating in the new pilot can apply. Following an initial validation process, the selected applicants will be invited to submit a full briefing package for scientific assessment. Submissions to the VDS pilot are expected until the third quarter of 2027. At the end of the pilot, the EMA will publish a lessons-learned report.

Source: EMA



ISTOCK



LENS ON HEALTH



EMOTIONAL TOLL. A healthcare worker holds his colleague during a break from handling the bodies of victims who perished in the flash floods and mudslide at the Maithili Barrack in Trishuli, Nuwakot district, Nepal REUTERS

When 'the doctor is in' without a pause

BY INVITATION



KAVITA ARORA



ISTOCK

When does a doctor stop being a doctor? Is it when she leaves the hospital or when the phone is finally switched off? For many professionals, the role remains long after work formally ends. It inhabits the body as readiness, responsibility and vigilance.

Research on emotional labour helps explain why. Healthcare professionals continuously regulate their own emotions while responding to others' fears and expectations. The invisible burden is in not only witnessing suffering, but responding to it in real time, under conditions of uncertainty. The smartphone has only sharpened this. It has altered the architecture of care: The possibility of crisis now travels home in a pocket. Even when no call comes, anticipation itself becomes work. The doctor leaves the room, but a part of the room stays with her.

Over time, this readiness leaves a physiological signature. The literature on allostatic load suggests that sustained responsibility and chronic vigilance reshape physiological systems, compressing the natural rhythm between activation and recovery into prolonged readiness interrupted by brief moments of rest. The deepest changes are not simply the coping mechanisms. They become ways of being: Heightened attunement, expanded responsibility, moral reflection and difficulty receiving care for oneself. The work gradually becomes part of the self.

This inner life is hardly new. In her book *In a Better Place: A Doctor's Journey*, Bornali Datta reminds us that medicine is never only about disease — in her words, it is "a story of human lives caught in the cusp of aspiration and reality". The suffering of patients and the frailties of caregivers remain deeply intertwined.

And yet, the hidden curriculum of healthcare in India still rewards

endurance, composure and self-sacrifice. Vulnerability is welcomed in patients but often treated with caution in professionals. Silence about this, however, extracts its own cost, turning understandable distress into private burdens.

What keeps people going despite this? In years of conversations with friends in the field of medicine, I've come to believe that "meaning making" probably does. Colleagues, humour, supervision, art, spirituality and witnessing human courage provide continuity. Healing is never a one-directional act. Those who care for others are themselves changed by what they witness.

Where are the spaces that encourage healthcare professionals to speak as human beings? Across the world, reflective practice groups, Balint groups, supervision spaces, narrative medicine circles and communities of inquiry have emerged, not to solve suffering but to think over it.

Who heals the healers? For generations, healthcare professionals have learned to compartmentalise, and these boundaries do matter: Patients deserve spaces centred on their needs. Can professionalism also involve reflection, awareness and ethical self-understanding, not just separation?

These are not questions with easy answers. They are questions worth staying with. The future of compassionate healthcare may depend not only on how we care for patients but also whether we can acknowledge that healers, too, are changed by the work of healing.

The writer is a founding cohort member of India Mental Health Alliance, a child and adolescent psychiatrist, and Co-founder of Children First. Views are personal

Making the community integral to palliative care

How Kozhikode-based organisation pioneered affordable and sustainable care for patients with life-limiting illnesses

V Sajeew Kumar

In 1993, when K Suresh Kumar began advocating palliative care in Kerala, few knew about the concept, and organised services for patients with life-limiting illnesses were almost non-existent. What began as the work of a handful of individuals has since evolved into one of the world's most widely recognised community-based palliative care models.

Kumar founded the Kozhikode-based Institute of Palliative Medicine (IPM) to ensure that people could access palliative care regardless of their economic or social circumstances.

Today, in Kerala, palliative care reaches nearly 60 per cent of those in need, compared with less than 2 per cent nationally. The model has been replicated in several regions outside Kerala, and the IPM



END CARE. K Suresh Kumar, Founder, Institute of Palliative Medicine

conducts training programmes for participants from around 60 countries, including high-income countries like Japan and Singapore.

Kumar's contribution to making palliative care affordable, sustainable and community-driven recently earned him the prestigious WHO South-East Asia Regional

Award for Public Health Champions.

Globally, palliative care has traditionally been associated with hospitals, specialised institutions and trained medical professionals. Kerala gradually moved away from that model, taking care into homes and neighbourhoods, and making communities an integral part

of the care system, he says.

Two features distinguish Kerala's approach. The first is placing the primary responsibility for palliative care at the local government-level rather than leaving it entirely within the healthcare system. The second is recognising that ordinary members of the community can make an important contribution to caring for people with serious illnesses.

The State now has more than 1,750 palliative care units at the grassroots level. Around 1,100 are run by local self-government institutions, about 500 by civil society organisations, and nearly 150 by political parties, which is rather unique globally.

"I was formally trained in palliative care in the United Kingdom, within an institution-based model. Even then, it was clear that the models developed in high-income countries would not readily suit the realities of countries like India,

although the way forward was less clear," he says.

One of the biggest challenges Kumar faced was in convincing people that palliative care could not be confined to clinical medicine. Care for the seriously ill was traditionally regarded as the responsibility of doctors, nurses and hospitals. But patients living with chronic and life-limiting illnesses often require much more than medical intervention. They need help with daily activities, emotional support, social interaction and dignity at the end of life.

The biggest gaps today, he says, are in quality assurance, consistency and standardisation of services, and equitable coverage across different geographical areas. Addressing these shortcomings will require stronger policies, sustainable funding and systematic capacity building across both community-based and professional systems.

QUICKLY.

EOS-05 finishes orbit manoeuvre



Chennai: ISRO's Earth Observation Satellite EOS-05 has successfully completed significant orbit manoeuvres as it heads towards Earth's Geosynchronous Orbit. The satellite was injected into the geosynchronous transfer orbit (GTO) in the early hours of Friday (September 4) by the space agency's Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle. From the GTO, the satellite will use in-built propulsion systems to further ascend its way to higher orbits before reaching the intended GEO at a distance of 36,000 kilometers. Post Friday's launch, V Naryanan, Chairman, ISRO, said the satellite will take around 4-5 days to reach the GEO. Once there, EOS-05 will be India's first imaging satellite in the GEO, a significant milestone for the country's strategic surveillance capabilities. OUR BUREAU

OPEC+ keeps oil output policy unchanged for Oct

OPEC+ kept its oil output policy unchanged for October at a meeting on Sunday as the group needs to agree on new quotas before deciding its next output steps. The meeting of seven core OPEC+ members — Saudi Arabia, Russia, Iraq, Kuwait, Algeria, Kazakhstan and Oman — comes as the Iran war continues to disrupt oil exports through the Strait of Hormuz. In August, OPEC+ agreed its production boost for September, completing a phased rollback of a 1.6 5million bpd supply cut first agreed in 2023. REUTERS

Upcoming BRICS Summit not likely to include bloc expansion on agenda

COMMON GROUND. Delhi wants to increase participation of new members, partner countries in specific areas

Amiti Sen
New Delhi



TAKING THE LEAD. India is seeking consensus on issues such as cross-border payments and economic cooperation

The BRICS Summit, to be hosted by India on September 12-13, is unlikely to consider further expansion of the grouping as there is no consensus among existing members on admitting more countries, officials said. "India is expected to use its chairship to focus on consolidating the grouping after its significant enlargement from five members to 11 over the past two years, and ensuring better integration of the new members and partner countries into its various mechanisms. There is no consensus yet on further expansion, so the matter isn't likely to be considered," an official tracking the matter told *businessline*. The enlarged grouping itself is grappling with the

more difficult task of arriving at common positions on geopolitical issues, especially the West Asia conflict. **DIFFERENCES CROP UP** Sharp differences between Iran and the UAE have made consensus more elusive, and are complicating efforts of arriving at an agreement on a

joint communique for the New Delhi summit, sources said. At the BRICS Summit, India is seeking consensus on issues such as cross-border payments, economic cooperation and reform of multilateral institutions, the official added. The summit aims to strengthen cooperation on

trade, investment, finance, technology and development, while advancing the bloc's push for a greater voice for the Global South in global institutions. **EXPANSION PROCESS** During the 2024 expansion process, more than 30 countries expressed interest in joining BRICS, either as full members or partners during the 2024 expansion process. Türkiye, Azerbaijan, Pakistan and Bangladesh are among countries that have expressed interest in full membership, while countries, including Malaysia, Nigeria, Thailand and Vietnam, have joined the partner-country framework. BRICS admission rules require consensus among existing members. The official noted that BRICS had evolved substantially over the past two dec-

ades, and required a lot of collaboration. "There are 35 tracks at the level of ministers and heads of agencies, which is a very, very elaborate programme for collaboration. It requires a lot of participation, engagement and effort," said the official. India has, therefore, sought to increase the participation of new members and partner countries in specific areas of cooperation. "We have made an effort this year to make sure that we encourage participation of new members and partner countries in certain sectors during our chairship," said the official. This is reflected in the proposed participation in the BRICS Summit in New Delhi, which includes not just leaders of BRICS members, but also all partner countries and a number of outreach invitees.

Reports of privatisation are incorrect, says ISRO

Our Bureau
Chennai

To quell internal anxieties about privatisation with its employees seeking a clarification, space body ISRO said on Sunday that reports of privatisation were "baseless and incorrect". "We wish to categorically state that ISRO will neither be privatised nor will its importance be diminished. ISRO will continue to remain India's principal institution for advanced space research and technology development, national and strategic missions, space science and exploration, and critical and frontier space capabilities," the marquee institution said in a statement.

ISRO'S ROLE The organisation noted that increased private participation in space is not about reducing ISRO's role. "It is about enabling ISRO to focus even more strongly on the next generation of India's space programme, while industry scales up mature

technologies and capabilities," it said. The government initiated reforms in 2020 and institutionalised it through the Indian Space Policy 2023, along with progressive liberalisation of FDI policy in the sector. The reforms should, therefore, be seen as "ecosystem expansion and capability multiplication, not privatisation", said ISRO.

HOW IT BEGAN The controversy began from recent public remarks made by Pawan Kumar Goenka, Chairman of the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPACE), that eventually ISRO will not make any launch vehicles, and that these would be done by the private sector. Following this, employee associations wrote to ISRO Chairman V Narayanan demanding urgent clarification. Employees, worried that ISRO will be diminished, sought clarifications regarding their employment and other concerns.

Assocham urges govt to take up visa, permanent magnets issue with China

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

As the stage gets set for the BRICS Summit on September 12-13, industry body Assocham has written to Rudendra Tandon, Secretary, Ministry of External Affairs, proposing a structured inter-ministerial engagement with the Ambassador of the People's Republic of China on residual visa, technology movement and supply chain matters affecting manufacturing here. According to sources, visa curbs on Indians from various sectors, including automotive and electronics, over

the last two years, along with restrictions on materials such as rare earth permanent magnets (REPM), had led to a disruption in manufacturing, prompting calls for a quick resolution to safeguard the supply chain. "The industry is, at present, scaling up capacity under Atmanirbhar Bharat in electric mobility, cell manufacturing, electronics and capital goods. In each of these areas, timely access to specialised equipment, technical personnel and certain critical inputs has become a key determinant of project schedules and unit costs. China continues to be a significant source in all of

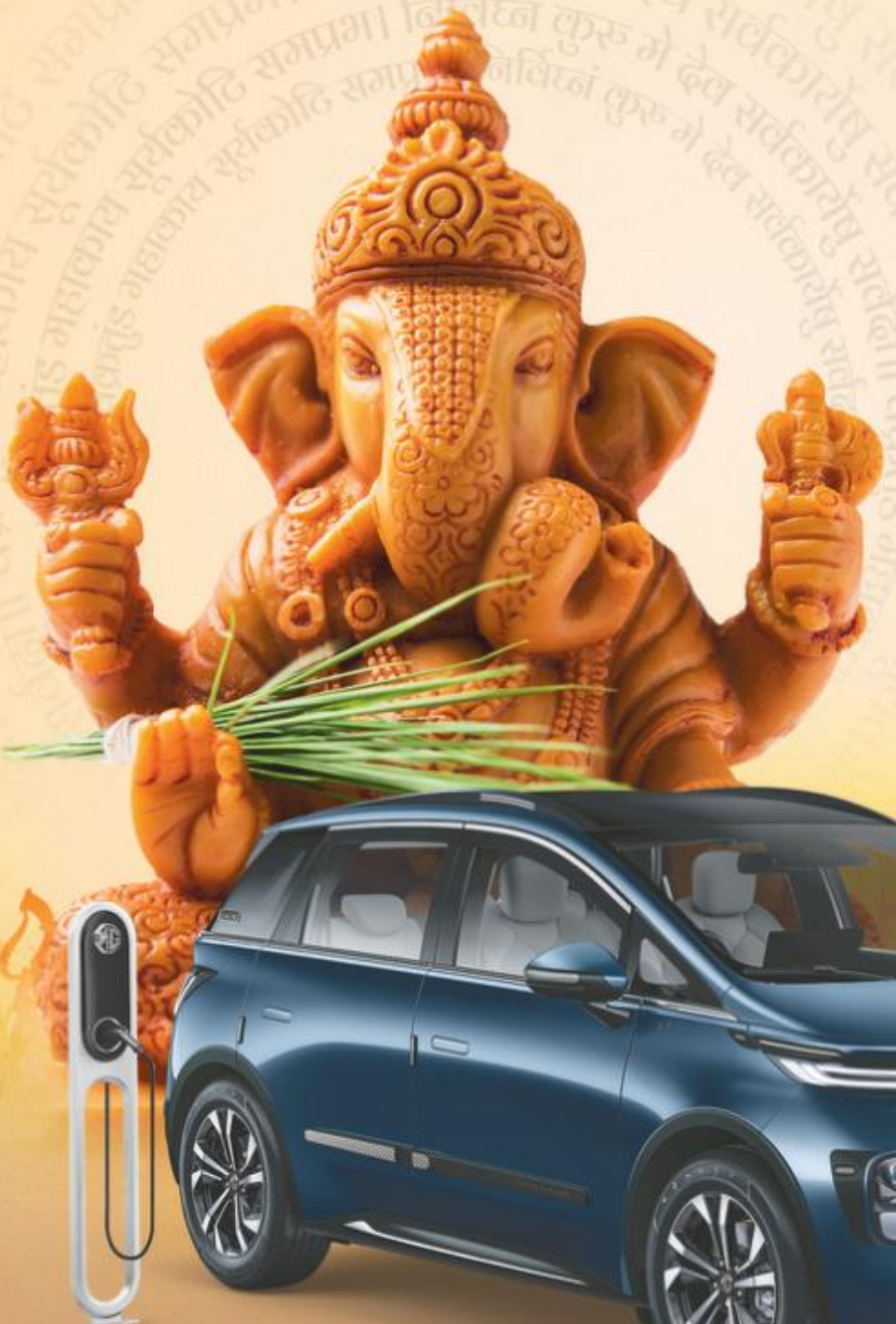
them," sources quoting the letter told *businessline*. **CRITICAL INPUTS** Industry sources also said that while there are no individual meetings lined up between the Chinese delegates and Indian auto industry, the high-level talks would include timely access to specialised equipment, technical personnel and certain critical inputs. More than 200 businessmen from China are set to arrive in India as part of the Chinese delegation. **BUILDING TIES** They will explore opportunities in various areas and

More than 200 businessmen from China are set to arrive in India as part of the Chinese delegation. They will explore opportunities in various areas build strong relations with India in those sectors, sources said. "A structured economic engagement, conducted wholly within the framework of the country's security requirements, would be of

considerable assistance to Indian manufacturers in meeting their commissioning schedules and in competing in global markets," the letter said. The industry body mentioned that commissioning and installing an imported plant ordinarily requires the presence of the supplier's engineers for defined periods and, thereafter, for warranty support. Assocham members have reported difficulty in securing the deployment of such personnel in time, with consequent slippage in project schedules. **CERTAIN CATEGORIES** Also, licensing requirements

applicable to REPM to certain specialised materials and specified categories of equipment have introduced an element of uncertainty into procurement planning. The difficulty lies in the timing and predictability of licensing decisions, rather than in the existence of the regime itself, it said. "Members report delay in obtaining business visas for Indian executives and engineers travelling to China for supplier audits, factory acceptance testing and technical training. Reciprocity in this regard would assist industry on both sides. Shipments against concluded contracts are, on occasion,

interrupted for reasons that appear to be administrative rather than commercial. Projects working to fixed commissioning dates find such interruptions particularly difficult to absorb," it added. Therefore, Assocham urged the government on giving permanence to the recent visa facilitation measures with indicative service timelines published, multiple entry business visas of suitable validity for technical personnel engaged in assignments that extend over several visits, and alignment of visa validity with equipment commissioning and warranty schedules.



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